we think too much

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34943167.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandoms:
Star Wars Legends: Force Unleashed - All Media Types, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Galen Marek | Starkiller, Yoda (Star Wars), Sheev Palpatine | Darth Sidious, Darth Vader

Additional Tags:
Tall Catra, catra gets a lightsaber, Human Catra (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Star Wars AU

Stats:
Published: 2021-11-05 Completed: 2021-11-20 Words: 25,532 Chapters: 10/10

we think too much

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34943167.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandoms:
Star Wars Legends: Force Unleashed - All Media Types, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Galen Marek | Starkiller, Yoda (Star Wars), Sheev Palpatine | Darth Sidious, Darth Vader

Additional Tags:
Tall Catra, catra gets a lightsaber, Human Catra (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Star Wars AU

Stats:
Published: 2021-11-05 Completed: 2021-11-20 Words: 25,532
Chapters: 10/10

we think too much

by catthorne

Summary

Catra is a mercenary hunting force sensitives; when the Empire brings her on for a special job and gives her own royal guard as a reward, can Catra cope with the old flame leading them?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The Bounty

The room grew colder around Palpatine.

"Good enough, Emperor?" He raised his arm, calling forth all of his power in a blast of lightning to strike down the young woman standing in front of him, arm outstretched. A blast that powerful would end any known lifeform in the galaxy; it could tear ships from the sky, rend space stations in two. The power surged through him, a familiar tingle ran down his arms to his fingertips-

Nothing happened. The woman was still standing, a smug smile on her face. Palpatine curled his fingers against his palms and let his arms rest on his throne once more, a smile of his own finding his lips.

"Perhaps. You claim you possess the ability to hunt down any force sensitive?"

Her arm dropped to her side and the chill left the room. "If they're powerful enough. Anyone that could even consider posing a threat should be enough."

"I assure you, bounty hunter," the words came almost like a curse, "he is powerful enough." Palpatine looked up at the few members of his court still in the room. "Leave us. We have important business that must be discussed and I do not want your disturbances."

Each of them bowed hastily and practically ran out of the room, terrified of displeasing the Sith Lord. He looked back at the woman; she was tall and trim, with an air of elegance that fell just short of haughtiness. Her brown hair fell just past her shoulders and her mismatched blue and yellow eyes glinted with hidden strength.

They sized him up as well, though perhaps less openly. "First I want a guarantee of payment. I don't care if you're the Empire, I

don’t do business like this unless I know it’s worth it.” Perhaps her impudence would have annoyed Palpatine any other time, but this mission was of utmost importance and he couldn’t afford to turn away or kill his best chance at seeing it completed.

“I can assure you you will be paid generously; but if you demand a guarantee, I will order half of it delivered as soon as you accept the contract.”

She considered for a second, then nodded. “Fine. Who am I looking for and how do you want them delivered?”

“Starkiller, alive,” the Emperor said, leaning back slightly. Her breath caught, briefly breaking her guise of disinterest. “Yes,” Palpatine said slowly, “ *the* Starkiller.”

She steeled herself and looked up, meeting the Emperor’s gaze. “Fine. But you better pay damn well if you expect me to bring in a myth for you.”

Palpatine only smiled.

Memories

Chapter Summary

Catra thinks about how she got here and remembers a very special someone

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra sighed to herself as she dropped into her navigation chair and flew out of the space station's docking bay. As tantalizing as the job had sounded when she first caught wind of it (a bounty directly from the Emperor, and one right up her alley hunting force users? Score!), she was wondering if maybe it wasn't as good an idea as she thought.

Starkiller? He was a legend, a myth that cropped up a few months earlier in the underworld. Until an hour ago she was sure he didn't exist. A force user powerful enough to take on Vader *and* the Emperor? Sure he died doing it but no way could something of that magnitude slip past her. And yet, she found herself closing her eyes and slipping into that trance state, probing the galaxy for those sunspots of power. There were some all over the place; force sensitives were still being born and lots of Jedi had escaped the Empire. But none of them matched her target.

Catra was 23 years old; though she vaguely remembered being told her family had royal lineage of some kind she had grown up as an orphan in the underbelly of Coruscant. Different people gave her different names, but none had stuck until a Mandalorian picked her up. She was six or seven, poor, and hungry when he found her. Despite being told not to, he had taken her in and offered her a place among his small clan. They were mercenaries; some called them bounty hunters, but more often they fought in civil wars for whichever side paid the most.

When she told him she didn't really have a name, he just laughed quietly and named her Catra. Something about sharp claws and strays.

She was tall, just over six foot with a graceful but well muscled build, honed by her training as a duelist. Her light brown skin and deep brown hair attracted plenty of male attention. It was nice to know she was gorgeous, though they weren't exactly her type. Her mind turned from her searching and wandered through old memories: training with the Mandalorians as a child, her powers blossoming as a teenager, her first lightsaber and set of armor… And her first love.

They were both seventeen, pitted on opposite sides of a bloody civil war on some planet she couldn't remember the name of. They had been there four months already and were itchy to move on, but their contract was until the war ended. Some rich and powerful noble had called them in to put down a rebellion led by a lesser noble and his supporters. Something about freedom from the hierarchy; Catra didn't make a habit of learning her enemies' motives.

Looking for a solution, it was suggested someone infiltrate the rebels and take down their leadership from the inside. Someone being Catra, of course. The Mandalorians would stand out like a sore thumb, but Catra still had some youthful naivete left. She left her armor behind, put on ragged local clothing, and showed up outside the rebel capital late in the evening. She was vetted for weapons or listening devices and allowed in, where she met with some of the rebel leaders and gave whatever sob story she had been provided this time; this wasn't new to her. Everything worked perfectly. She was allowed in and very quickly became a trusted advisor. It wasn't hard when she was being fed information from the outside. The plan was proceeding smoothly; in a few weeks, the heads of the rebellion would be killed and she would mysteriously disappear. Of course, everything went wrong.

One night, as Catra slipped out of her quarters to have a holomeeting with her clan, she noticed strange sounds coming

from the training room nearby. Sneaking in, she encountered a girl furiously attacking the dummies. Her long blonde hair was tucked up in a messy ponytail, muscles rippled under a sleeveless training shirt and pants, and in her hands she held twin vibroblades. Her strikes were powerful but sloppy; whether it was fatigue or lack of training Catra wasn't sure, nor did she care. She was fixated on this girl.

She didn't know how long she stood there, watching this otherworldly being beat up imaginary enemies before she turned around, locking her with warm blue eyes. Her face changed from surprise to suspicion to understanding and back to surprise all in a second. The vibroblades fell to the ground with a pair of *clang!* s.

Catra spoke first, stuttering, "Oh, I-I'm sorry I just- I was out to get some air-"

"Oh god please don't tell my dad I was just-" The two spoke over each other for a moment before Catra snapped back to her senses, raising her hands to cut them both off.

"Okay, um, I feel like I wasn't supposed to see," she gestured at the dummies, "whatever this is."

"Please, please pretend you didn't see any of this," the other girl begged. "My dad would kill me if he found out I'm doing this."

"What the hell *are* you doing?" Catra shot back. "And who's your dad, anyways?"

The girl's head tilted, her eyebrows scrunching. "I- You don't know who I am?"

"Not a fucking clue."

"Oh. OH. Um," she stuttered. It was obvious she was used to being recognized; Catra was used to kids that thought too highly of themselves but this girl was different. She didn't sound offended, just *surprised* . And maybe… Relieved?

“Should I?” she asked, trying to slip back into the character she was supposed to be playing.

“No, no I uh, I guess not. I just- well, you work with my dad and the other nobles so much that I thought you might.”

There it was. The girl was nobility; it didn’t matter how much the rebellion claimed they wanted to destroy the nobles system, they still expected to be treated as above everybody else.

“Oh. We don’t exactly talk about personal stuff. They- well, they don’t really talk to me at all. Just at me. And around me.” The girl nodded, as if she understood. She probably did.

“I’m Adora, by the way.” She awkwardly extended her hand.

“Catra.” *Holy shit did I just tell her my real name?* She shook her hand before she had time to think it over.

“Catra? I thought-”

“Nickname. It’s a… nickname. From when I was a kid.” Adora nodded and made a small “oh” with her mouth.

“I’m honored that you trust me with it,” she said, completely sincerely. As stupid as it was, Catra’s heart melted. *Useless fucking lesbian, you’re on a mission. She’s your enemy.*

Catra shook herself awake. Starkiller’s location burned at the edge of her mind as her ship came out of hyperspace.

“Are you okay, Master Catra?” She looked over her shoulder at the droid she had put together from scrap parts.

“Yeah, Hope, I’m fine. Just a bad dream.”

“Ah. The lady Adora again?” Catra scowled. Damn droid knew her too well.

"Yeah. Again. It's not important."

"I could always find her for you. I'm sure-"

"She wants nothing to do with me, Hope. She made that clear. Drop it." She looked away, blinking away the tears.

"As you wish, Master." Hope went back to their duties around the ship.

Finally, Catra looked out of the ship at the slimeball of a planet below them. Dagobah, supposedly. Starkiller's signature was still strong there; he couldn't have left yet.

"Hope! Bring us in to land at the coordinates I left in the computer!" She barely registered the droid's affirmative as she went to prepare.

After testing the air to make sure it was safe, Catra stepped out onto the planet's swampy surface. From the neck down, she wore her black and silver Mandalorian armor. She forwent the helmet for a black hood pulled tight around her face. On her waist she wore her curved lightsaber. She walked about a hundred feet from the ship and tapped the comm in her ear.

"You read me, Hope? No interference?"

"Loud and clear, Master Catra," they responded.

"Good. Keep the ship primed. We're gonna have a very angry and very powerful Jedi to deal with when I get back."

"Understood. Do be safe."

Catra grinned. "No promises." She cut the connection and slipped off into the swamps, chasing the power source she felt. She was so close now she could feel it without her unique abilities. Something felt off, though.

Chapter End Notes

Any excuse to write Catradora as useless lesbians is a good excuse

Flashbacks

Chapter Summary

Catra gets into more than one heated encounter and a familiar voice sparks memories

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She knew something was wrong when the power split; suddenly part of it was behind her and *very* close. She spun, prepping her disruption and grabbing for her lightsaber as a small, green figure hobbled out of the trees.

"Hmm," it murmured. "Come seeking wisdom, you have not. Searching for something, you are."

"Yeah, and it's sure as hell not *you* ," Catra scoffed. "What are you and what kind of 'wisdom' would I be looking for from you?"

"Conflicted, you are. But about your purpose here, it is not," the creature continued, seemingly unaware she had spoken.

"Alright, either answer me or I'll cut you down where you stand," Catra said, igniting her black lightsaber. The creature was immediately obsessed with it but said nothing. "Answer me, dammit!"

Catra closed the distance quickly, hovering the saber against its neck. "Hmm," it muttered again. "Sense darkness from you, I do not." It turned and walked away, leaving Catra alone in the clearing.

She tapped her comm. "Hope, did you get that?"

"Yes, Master. The creature doesn't match any records I can find."

What the hell is this planet? "Keep looking. Make sure you didn't miss anything."

"As you say." The channel closed again. Catra clipped her saber back onto her belt, turning to the other power she felt. Steeling herself for whatever else was in this blasted swamp, she resumed her journey.

Her lightsaber proved invaluable for cutting through the swamp's overgrowth, though she thankfully didn't come across any more local creatures she had to defend from. She had filed the weird green thing away in her memory to look into later. She could still feel it's power at the edge of her senses but she was fixated now, locked onto Starkiller. He was close now and the power radiating off of him was intoxicating.

A few more minutes and she could see him, slowly exiting a cave hidden among the vines. He wore a simple jumpsuit and a few pieces of armor, Imperial make. Two lightsabers hung from his waist. As calm as he appeared, anger-no, pure *rage* poured from him like a flood of pure dark energy. Catra calmed her mind, watching him closely and waiting for her chance to strike.

He walked out, slowly, cautiously, analyzing the swamp like he was looking for something. Now that she could see him more clearly he seemed troubled, like he had just gone through something bordering on traumatizing. Another moment and he was below her, oblivious to her in the trees over his head. He could tell something was wrong; his hand rested on one of his sabers, his muscles tensed, but he remained still. As he took one more cautious step forward, Catra dropped.

Her elbow came down across the back of his head, sending him stumbling forward and stunning him momentarily. It gave Catra the edge, but not for long. She drew her saber quickly, but Starkiller was faster than she expected. He leapt to his feet, sabers in hand and lunged at her, delivering a powerful blow

downwards. She caught the blades with her own, deflecting them to the side and stepping in to strike but Starkiller was already gone, flipping over her head and bringing his sabers around to strike at her back. She parried again but she was on the defensive now, being driven back by a hailstorm of deadly blows.

Catra had dueled powerful Jedi before, but nothing on the level of Starkiller. And even so, it seemed wrong. She had chosen to attack before dampening the area on a whim, hoping to see how powerful he truly was but now, thinking, she realized that the Starkiller of legends would have killed her effortlessly. So why was she alive?

She didn't have time to consider the question seriously yet; all of her energy had to go towards staying alive now. She could already feel herself growing tired, her reactions slowing ever so slightly. She couldn't win this fight on skill or power alone, so she waited for an opening and let herself be launched backwards by a particularly powerful force-infused blow. Now, with a moment, she could set her plan in action.

"You know, the Starkiller I heard stories about would've killed me already," she taunted, focusing what energy she had left. He didn't respond, just looked at her, chest heaving. He was taking full advantage of this lull to gather his own strength again. "So that means what? That the stories were exaggerated? 'Cuz I don't think so."

Starkiller deactivated his sabers and clipped them to his sides. A rush of dark energy surrounded him. *Okay, fuck, make this quick or you're dead* . "No, I think I know what it means. You aren't Starkiller, are you?" She raised her arm, twisting the force; it was everywhere. The ground, the trees, the very air around her. The humid swamp went cold. "Isn't that right?" she said, curling her fingers in and deactivating her lightsaber, "clone?"

The word sealed her fate; Starkiller surged forward, his arms extended to strike her down with a blast of dark lightning- and still she stood. Starkiller looked at his hands, not understanding

why the force wasn't obeying him. He grabbed for his lightsabers, drawing them and activating them- and again nothing happened. The sabers clicked and remained dormant.

"You feel it? The way you're slower, weaker? Your connection to the force is severed. You're all the same. You think the force is your greatest strength, the thing that makes you special. You use it constantly, passively to enhance your mind and body. It even flows through your lightsabers; technological wonders, yes, but useless without their crystals. Crystals that rely on the force just as much as you do."

"What the hell did you *do* ?" he shouted, the first time he had spoken to her. Catra grinned smugly.

"I have my own unique powers, clone. But that's not important. What is important is that you're coming with me," she said, igniting her lightsaber again. It glowed an angry, fiery red now, imbued with the dark energy of Starkiller and Dagobah. "I'm being paid for bringing you in alive and you're gonna make it easy for me. I promise you don't stand a chance now." Catra strode forward, catching the blow he threw at her with ease and disarming him. She took his lightsabers and delivered a powerful kick to his ribs. His wrists were clasped with the cuffs she carried as she dragged him to his feet. "It's a long walk back to the ship, so you better be damn good."

He scowled, refusing to answer. Catra pushed him back into the swamps, double tapping her comm to let Hope know she was successful and on her way back.

Catra felt the other presence several times on the way back, but the creature never made itself known. Starkiller remained silent, not only all the way onto the ship but throughout the entire journey. Catra wasn't able to sleep; if she ever stopped draining the force from around her, Starkiller would be able to escape with

ease. Hope kept watch over him while she navigated back to the space station she had first met Palpatine on.

The Emperor felt the chill before Catra entered the throne room. He silenced whatever quarrel his advisors were having. The doors slid open and his royal guards stood at attention. Still in her armor, Catra walked in, pulling Starkiller behind her. She threw him on the ground in front of the Emperor, crossing her arms smugly.

"Here's your damn clone. You're gonna want a way to stop him from using the force if you plan on keeping him."

"Arrangements have been made, hunter. Do not concern yourself with my plans," Palpatine said, smiling evilly at the clone.

"Trust me, I'm not. I'm just here for my payment," Catra shot back, putting her hands on her hips.

Palpatine pointed a gnarled finger at a guard. "You, take the prisoner to his cell. And you," he said, turning his finger to a military officer, "give the woman her reward."

Catra's hand went to her lightsaber. "If you think you can kill me-"

"I assure you, ma'am, we have no intent of harming you," the officer interrupted. "I am in charge of the Emperor's royal guards. We would like to offer you a position with the Empire, hunting down rogue Jedi. All needs will be provided for, courtesy of the Emperor, and you will be in command of a personal guard entourage from our ranks."

Catra stared in disbelief for a moment before shaking her head. "No, I'm here for my credits. I'm not interested in being here longer than I have to."

"I'm afraid I must insist you reconsider," the officer said. "The Emperor has made a very generous offer."

"Not the soldier type, thanks. I'll be going. You can transfer the credits on my way out."

"Nor are we asking you to be," Palpatine said slowly. "You will work exactly as you do now, but with the Empire's direction and support."

Catra scowled. "You don't take no for an answer, do you? Fine. But I have a condition."

The officer scoffed and opened his mouth to speak, but Palpatine cut him off with a raised finger. "And what condition would that be, girl?"

She looked over her shoulder at the guards standing at the door. "I want to pick my guards myself. And no men." The officer's back straightened in indignation, but again Palpatine cut him off.

"As you wish. Commander, please begin the process of selecting recruits for our new friend. And send a message to Lord Vader. I require his presence at his earliest convenience." The officer bowed and spun, gesturing for Catra to follow him as he transmitted the orders through his comm.

"I don't know what authority you think you have, but I can assure you that you do not."

Catra only scoffed. "I wouldn't be sure about that. You seem pretty replaceable, Commander. I'm one of a kind." He set his jaw and turned away as his face flushed with anger. "Aw, hit a nerve? Too bad. Now show me my options."

He keyed in a passcode to the door and it opened to the women's barracks. It was orderly, though some of the women themselves were less so. Even so, they all snapped to attention when they walked in.

“This,” he said, gesturing to Catra, “is the Emperor’s new pet. She will be selecting a squad to accompany her on her missions from you lot.” They looked between each other and Catra, sizing her up. “Any volunteers?”

A brunette stepped forward. She was a few inches taller than Catra and well-built. “I’m the best damn shield in this barracks and that’s not disputed. You want someone to keep you alive out there, I’m your girl.” Catra nodded.

“Then I’ll take you.”

Another woman stepped forward. She was small and lithe, with dark brown skin and warm amber eyes. “I graduated top of my class as a pilot. Nobody knows their way around a cockpit like I do.” Catra nodded again and she crossed the room to stand next to them.

A helmeted girl with a rifle slung across her back stepped forward. “I’m a scout-sniper. I can handle reconnaissance, long-range elimination, and tactical support.”

“How well do you handle that rifle?” Catra asked.

“Better than any Imperial sniper in the galaxy.” Even through the helmet’s metallic distortion there was pride in her voice. Catra smiled.

“Then welcome to the team.”

Twins stepped forward; they were about half a head shorter than Catra with short black hair and piercing blue eyes. “Heavy weapons expert and demolitions expert, respectively,” the one on the left said, gesturing to the two of them. “We’re your best bet in a firefight.”

“Demolitions? Sounds fun.”

“Aye, sir,” the one on the right responded. “And if I may?” she gestured to another woman, standing slightly to the side. “This is

our best medic, and she's a genius with tech. She's designed half my explosives."

"Then I see no reason to separate the two of you," Catra replied before turning to the officer again. "Is that enough?"

Before he could respond, the door slid open behind them.

"Hey, Catra," came the familiar voice.

Adora's head rested on her shoulder while Catra giggled. "Your friends sound awful," she murmured when she finally stopped.

"Yeah, they are," Adora replied, smiling. "What about you? You have any good childhood stories?"

Catra froze. She thought about her childhood; being an orphan on Coruscant didn't exactly make for good stories. A lot of pain, and then the Mandalorians. Sure, she loved them like family but they weren't big fans of fun.

"I- No, not really," she said quietly.

"Oh," Adora whispered. "I'm sorry."

Catra tightened the arm around her waist. "It's not your fault, really. Just something I prefer not to talk about."

Adora nodded but pulled back. "Catra… I love this. I love us. But I feel like I barely know you. You never talk about yourself."

"There's not much to say. I was an orphan-" Adora cut off the story she had been fed.

"We all know that. But that's not who you are. There's so much more to you than why you joined the rebellion. Why won't you let me in?" There were tears in Adora's eyes. They had already had

similar conversations to this in the few weeks since they had met and fallen for each other. None of them had gone well.

"Adora, I-I can't," Catra choked out, turning her face away.

"Why not? You can trust me, you know that."

Catra swallowed thickly and turned to face Adora. "I'm not-I'm not who I say I am, Adora."

"Then tell me, Catra. I don't care if you lied about your life, I know I care about you."

"Adora…"

"Catra, please." Adora was crying now.

And so she spilled. Catra told her everything, from the streets of Coruscant to being adopted by the Mandalorians, every war they fought in or bounty they claimed, and finally why she was really in the rebellion.

"I'm sorry, Adora. I really am. I-"

"Was it all a lie?" Adora asked hoarsely.

"No! No of course not! Adora, I-I love you. That's real. We're real," Catra promised, holding Adora's hands in her own.

"But you're here to kill everyone."

"No, Adora, no. I'm supposed to kill just the leaders, to end this rebellion."

"And then what, Catra? You leave with your 'clan' and I never see you again?" Catra squeezed her hands.

"No, I-I was gonna bring you with me. I never wanted to leave you." Catra was pleading now, desperate to salvage her relationship with Adora.

"You have to kill my only family, Catra."

"You said yourself you hate him! He treats you like shit, Adora. We can get out of here! If you just go with me, please! We can see the galaxy together, just you and me! I've been saving credits to buy my own ship and leave my clan behind, I almost have enough. This job will do it, it'll be the last one I need with them."

Adora looked back at her, almost hopeful. She opened her mouth to speak but was interrupted by an earth-shattering explosion. Catra went cold. Their heads both snapped towards the sound to see the meeting room of the palace explode outwards.

"No. No no no what did they do? What did they do?" Catra shouted. Adora looked at her with fear in her eyes.

"I was supposed to be in that room. If you hadn't made me sneak off…"

"Adora, I had nothing to do with this. This wasn't me, I just wanted to see you, I swear." But Catra's protests didn't matter when a pair of armored Mandalorians appeared in the courtyard, blasters drawn.

"Catra," one of them called, voice amplified by his helmet, "come on. Job's done. You did good, kid."

"This wasn't the plan! What are you doing?" she screamed. The other Mandalorian answered, his voice gruff.

"This was always the plan, kid. Good job separating the girl. Now cuff her and let's get out of here."

Adora was standing now, fear plain on her face. She stumbled back, away from Catra.

"Adora, please. Come with me. Please!" Adora shook her head. Catra was crying now too, her hand extended for Adora's.

"Cat! Do as you're told! Get the girl!" But Catra remained still, tears running down her face as Adora turned and ran. Blasters primed and the Mandalorians fired at her. Catra's instincts kicked in; she yanked her lightsaber from the pouch she wore and deflected them, giving Adora the cover she needed to escape. The Mandalorians stopped quickly and approached Catra, who had fallen to her knees and started sobbing, her shoulders shaking violently as tears fell from her eyes.

Those same tears pricked Catra's eyes now, but she buried them. The familiar blonde hair was in a tight ponytail. The same vibroblades she had carried six years ago hung on her back. She had a red Imperial Guard helmet under her arm and an officer's patch on her uniform. She turned away from Catra.

"Emperor sent me. I'm supposed to lead her squad," she said, gesturing at Catra.

"No," Catra finally choked out.

"Emperor's orders. Apparently he wants his new asset as safe as possible." Adora looked her over as she spoke. Her voice lowered and she leaned in closer. "I'm not happy about it either."

Catra felt her heart drop. Adora really didn't want her. When she had walked in some part of her hoped that it was because she wanted to be near her but- *Wait, what the fuck is Adora DOING here?*

The question steeled her nerves. "Fine," she said. "But you're under *my* command, not the other way around."

"Whatever you say. Girls, pack up your gear and get ready to go." The squad Catra had picked saluted and got to work, helping each other gather whatever they needed. "And make it snappy. We've already received orders from the Emperor."

Adora spun on her heel and walked out, Catra chasing her. She led them down several different corridors, eventually ducking into a room. Catra followed, stepping in beginning to speak.

“Adora, what the hell are you doing here? And why-” She was cut off as Adora slammed her against the door.

“Shut the fuck up, Cat,” she growled, then grabbed her by the hair and kissed her.

Chapter End Notes

I’m leaving the implied spice to your imaginations, have fun

Never

Chapter Summary

Angst and fluff all mixed together, plus the Emperor's first mission

Catra's armor was strewn across the floor; her chest was heaving as she leaned against the wall. She could feel her face burning.

"What the *hell* , Adora?" she choked out, still breathless.

"Don't talk. Stop talking. Don't fucking ruin it." Adora was similarly collapsed, next to her but at a *polite* distance. Catra did as she was told, keeping her mouth closed. Instead, she took the time to admire Adora. *How did she get more beautiful?* "Get dressed, Cat. We can't sit here forever."

"Why not?" Catra didn't mean for that to sound so damn *whiny* but holy shit she missed this. She missed *Adora* .

"What did I say about talking? Clothes. Now."

After a moment, Catra nodded. She wordlessly redressed and left the room. Adora slumped down lower against the wall after she left.

"What the hell am I doing? It's bad enough it's Catra but she's my *superior* now," she said to herself. She looked around the room. "Right. Clothes. Where the hell are my…" she trailed off, humming quietly as she collected her clothes and got dressed.

Catra was still waiting outside the door when Adora left. "Took you long enough," she teased. Adora only glared at her. Catra sighed. "Adora, listen-"

"Save it, Catra. I don't care."

"Adora, I get it if you're angry at me or if you hate me but you also just fucked my brains out. I'm at least owed a few explanations." Adora whirled, her stare darkening.

"I don't owe you *shit* , Catra. You betrayed me and here you are acting like nothing happened."

"Oh, *I'm* acting like nothing happened? I'm sorry, which one of us just led me into some side room and fucked me? No, you're gonna fucking talk to me now and tell me what the *hell* is going on!" Catra was shouting now but she didn't care. There was nobody around to hear, anyways.

"What's going on is that I'm in charge of the girls you picked as your personal fucking soldiers now, which means I have to run around the galaxy and protect you while you play Emperor's pet!"

"What, you think I *asked* for any of this? I showed up to run one job and got coerced into whatever this is! And what are you even *doing here* , Adora?"

"What does it look like I'm doing here, Catra? I'm an Imperial Guardsman!"

"But, why?" Catra was confused; Adora stated it like it was plain as day what she was doing as a guard.

"Where do you think I had to go after you destroyed my whole life, Catra?..." Adora's voice was softer now too.

"I… Adora please…"

"Please what, Cat? 'Go with me?' It doesn't look like I have a choice now."

"I tried to tell you, that wasn't my fault. It was never to go down that way and then I met you and that complicated things even more-"

Adora cut off her rambling. "'Complicated?' Is that all I was to you? A complication?"

Catra was crying now, barely holding back sobs. "No, Adora, I loved you, I-I still love you. I've thought about you every day since I left."

"You ruined *everything* , Catra. You destroyed the rebellion. You killed my father. You almost killed *me* ."

"Please listen to me! I had nothing to do with that! They never told me that was part of the plan, I swear it."

"It doesn't matter, Cat. You were still a part of it. You were still going to leave me."

"No I wasn't," Catra whispered. Adora's eyes locked to hers.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, her voice low.

"I…" Catra's voice broke again and she turned away, wiping at her eyes. "It doesn't matter. You'd still hate me. I fucked everything up and I'm so, so sorry."

"No, Cat. Tell me what you meant." When no response came, Adora stepped forward and put her hand on Catra's shoulder. "Catra. Talk to me. Tell me."

"I would've stayed!" Catra cried suddenly. Adora drew back, shock writing itself across her features. "I would've stayed," she repeated quietly. "If you said you wouldn't go with me. I would've stayed with you. I would've come clean to the rebellion and fought with you."

"Cat…"

"It doesn't matter, Adora. Not anymore. I lost my chance. I fucked it up and I lost you and now I can't get you out of my head." Catra turned away and left before Adora could say another word.

Catra still didn't speak to her when she reached the ship. Her and her droid rushed around, prepping for launch and barking orders.

"Hope, are you sure we have enough fuel?"

"Quite, Master Catra. The Imperials were gracious enough to refuel the ship before you returned."

"Could've at least asked me," she muttered under her breath, though silently she was thankful she wouldn't have to worry about it. Starship fuel was expensive, even relative to how much the Empire had paid her for Starkiller. Speaking of, "Hope, what'd you do with that clone's sabers?"

Hope cocked their head. "Stored them in your room, like always."

"Good. Thanks, Hope." Catra finally turned to Adora. "You're late, *Captain* . Hope, this is the commanding officer for our retinue. Adora, this is Hope."

"Ah! The Lady Adora. How wonderful to meet you," Hope said.

"Shut up, Hope," Catra snarled. "I built them myself a couple years ago. No good for fighting, but a decent navigator and a damn good cook."

Adora looked at the droid for a moment before returning it's greeting and looking back at Catra. "'Lady Adora.' I like that."

"Of course you would, princess." The venom in Catra's voice was totally mismatched from the crying mess Adora had spoken with in the hallway. "Get to the cockpit and make sure your pilot doesn't hit anything on the way out of here."

"What's the matter? Don't trust my girls?" Catra scoffed. " *Seriously* ? I trained them myself!"

Catra looked up from whatever she was doing, staring at Adora like she couldn't tell if she was serious. "That's *why* I don't trust them, hotshot."

"Excuse you!" Adora's indignation was partially exaggerated, but she had a feeling Catra wasn't totally joking. Catra, for her part, just walked away. Adora turned and went to the cockpit like Catra said, where the final launch preparations were being made.

Catra walked into her quarters and flopped into bed, exhausted. She booted on the AI she had commissioned for her bedside. "Light, how long since I last slept?"

"One moment, analyzing vitals." Catra closed her eyes, trying to relax her muscles. "Thirty-seven hours and fourteen minutes."

Fuck, really? "Tell Hope to oversee launch and navigation. Wake me up in six hours."

"Typical health requirements would suggest an eight hour sleep cycle at this time," Light responded.

"Six hours, Light. Earlier if I'm needed."

"As you say." Light powered off and Catra passed out almost immediately.

She woke up blearily and immediately sneezed off the lock of hair resting on her face. "What the-"

She was cut off as Adora's sleeping form shifted slightly, snuggling closer to her. *Am I dreaming?*

"Sensors indicate that you are not."

"Shhh, hush Light!" Catra hissed. "Did I ask that out loud?"

"Yeah," Adora murmured into her chest.

"Fuck, are you awake?"

"I am now." Adora pulled back a bit and Catra sat up, scooting to press her back to the wall.

"Then you mind explaining what you're doing in my bed?"

"Records show that the Lady Adora entered sixty-three minutes after you fell asleep in search of a bed for herself. Lacking a better option, she chose to sleep in yours."

"Didn't fucking ask you, Light," Catra groaned.

"Well, she's not wrong," Adora said. "There was nowhere left to sleep after everybody else got comfortable so I stayed in here. I didn't think you'd mind this much."

"It's not that I *mind* , I just would've liked some fucking *warning!* "

"I tried," Adora said, smiling meekly. "You didn't wake up so…"

"So you just made yourself comfortable?"

"It's not the first time."

"We were *dating* the other times, Adora!"

"We just fucked, I figured it was close enough!

Before Catra could respond, Light cleared her (digital) throat. "Fuck! Light, power down

and stop monitoring the room until I tell you otherwise."

"As you wish," Light responded before powering down.

"Stop monitoring the room?" Adora raised an eyebrow.

"I cannot fucking stand you," Catra replied, groaning again. "What happened to hating

me? It was easier like that."

Adora faltered, her features sobering. "I realized that… Maybe you were telling the truth. About everything that happened. And…"

Catra looked at her softly, startled. "And what?"

"Would you really have stayed for me?" Adora asked, her voice breaking on the final word.

"Of course I would have, Adora. You were- you *are* everything to me. Sure I wanted to explore the galaxy all on my own whims, but I couldn't imagine doing it without you."

Adora's eyes watered as she looked at Catra. "But what about your freedom? Even before you told me the truth, you told me about exploring the galaxy and finally being free."

"This starship didn't give me freedom, Adora. *You* did." That broke Adora; she started sobbing, unable to tear her eyes from Catra's.

"Cat, I-"

Catra covered her mouth with a finger. "Don't talk, not right now. Just let it out." She pulled Adora in, holding her close while she cried. Tears of her own rolled down her cheeks. She held her there for what felt like an hour.

When Adora finally calmed down, Catra let her pull back slightly. "I'm so sorry, Cat," she whispered.

"No, Adora. I'm sorry. I should've told you earlier, then none of this would have happened."

Adora shook her head weakly. "I should've listened to you when you told me the truth. I… I wanted to go with you, you know. I really did. And I-" She cut off as she choked on another

sob, looking away from Catra. “I never hated you, Catra,” she finally got out, then broke down into another crying fit.

Catra just held her, those words echoing in her mind. *I never hated you.* How could she not? She said it herself: Catra destroyed her whole life. She abandoned her. She lied to her and broke her.

Adora was asleep again by the time she finished crying. Catra gently tucked her back into bed and left the room, giving Light orders to tell her as soon as she was awake. She made her way to the cockpit, where the pilot and Hope were managing the ship’s course.

“Hey,” she said from the doorway. The pilot jumped a little but Hope simply greeted her. “Don’t think I ever caught your name,” Catra said as she dropped into the second seat.

“Oh, uh, Glim. But everyone calls me Sparkles.”

Catra smiled wryly. “Sparkles?”

“On account of my sparkly personality, of course! That and I, uh, got pranked with a glitter bomb first day of training. Never quite lived it down.” Catra chuckled.

“A glitter bomb? In Imperial training?”

“Yeah. Our instructors weren’t too happy, but they never caught who did it.”

“Not surprised. I know kids that could run circles around Imperials. No offense, of course.”

Sparkles laughed. “None taken. Being an Imperial Guardsman doesn’t mean I don’t know how useless so many of our forces are.” Catra smiled and they shared a comfortable silence for a while, slowly settling into a rhythm to pilot the ship at max efficiency.

After about two hours, Sparkles looked up. “We’re approaching the target world. The brief is in the computers if you wanna read it before we land.”

Catra nodded and pulled it up, but didn’t get far before Hope leaned down to her. “Light reports the Lady Adora is awake.”

“Excuse me. I’ve got something I have to attend to,” Catra said to Sparkles. She just nodded and Catra left, making her way back to her quarters through the main room, full of the Guardsman prepping. She slipped through her door and shut it behind her, crossing to the bed quickly.

“Hey, Cat,” Adora murmured sleepily.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra replied. “How do you feel?”

“Better, I think. You could’ve stayed.”

Catra shook her head. “I wish, but I had to make sure Sparkles wasn’t getting us lost.” Adora smiled at the nickname. “Come on, let’s get you up and around.”

She nodded and let them help her out of bed. Catra helped her get dressed, every movement light and tender.

“I missed you,” Adora whispered as Catra helped her pull a shirt on.

“I missed you too,” Catra said after a beat. “We both have a lot to catch up on, I think.”

“You mean- would you want to?...” Adora asked carefully.

Catra finished settling the shirt over her body and turned Adora around slowly. “There’s nothing I want more,” she said quietly, pressing their foreheads together. “Can I kiss you?”

Adora nodded and Catra pressed their lips to hers. It was gentle, loving. It reminded her of the kisses the two had shared in

secret all those years ago.

When Catra broke the kiss, she didn't pull away. She kept their foreheads pressed together, a thumb stroking Adora's cheek. "Let's catch up after we finish whatever mission this is, okay?" Adora nodded. Catra finally pulled away, leaving one more kiss on the tip of her nose and turning to change into her armor. Adora didn't move, totally unable to look away from Catra.

Eventually, Catra turned to look back at her. "Something wrong?"

"You're beautiful," Adora murmured.

"So are you, dummy," Catra said, pulling her helmet out of the small closet hidden in the wall. Tucking it under her arm, she stepped back to Adora and pulled her in with one arm. "I love you, Adora."

"I love you too." Catra smiled and kissed her again, then let her go and walked out of the room.

Catra had her helmet on by the time she was through the door. "Light, pull up the mission brief on my helmet display and summarize."

"As you wish." A pause. "The Emperor has tasked you and your assigned Guardsmen with assisting Imperial forces in defeating a rogue Jedi located on Ryloth. It is believed this Jedi is aiding the local rebellion forces.

"Oh good. Putting down rebellions. Haven't done that enough."

"It would appear the Empire is rather aware of your history."

Catra winced. "Just great. Anything unique about this Jedi I should know?"

"No. The Emperor has requested the Jedi killed."

"No problem." Catra turned off her voice dampener as Adora walked into the room behind her. "You've all read the mission brief?" At the assenting nods from around the room, Catra continued. "Good. This is gonna be quick and clean. We'll coordinate with the Empire's soldiers on the ground to draw the Jedi out. I'll engage them in combat, the rest of you will follow Adora's lead to make sure I'm covered and the Jedi doesn't escape. Under no circumstances will you engage the target directly. Understood?" She received affirmatives from each woman and nodded. "Adora? Give your girls their orders."

Catra left the room as Adora began laying out a plan, walking into the cockpit with Hope. "Bring us in gentle, Hope. We don't wanna spook the Imps."

"Understood, Master Catra. Beginning final descent now."

They broke through the atmosphere with minimal turbulence. Immediately, Imperial forces were in contact.

"Identify yourself."

"This vessel is here under the orders of the Emperor. I'm sending over necessary documentation now," Catra replied. Working for the Empire like this may be new, but getting clearance to land at their ports wasn't.

"Received. You are cleared to land. An escort will be waiting for you."

"Got it," Catra muttered as the channel closed. "Hope, take us in on those coordinates."

"Yes sir."

The landing went as well as entry had. Catra made her way to the ship's exit, motioning for the guards to follow her. They were in full regalia, cloaks and helmets included. The only

distinguishing features were their individual insignias, denoting rank and position.

Adora moved up to Catra's left, matching her pace in silence. Four of the guards fanned out behind them while two assumed positions at the bottom of the walkway. It was obviously a well-rehearsed procedure for them.

Catra descended slowly and cautiously, the guards following. Four stormtroopers stood flanking an officer, who bowed as they came into view.

"I apologize that the commandant was not able to greet you himself, but he is rather occupied at the moment," she said.

"Yeah, I hear you've got quite the rebellion on your hands."

"Indeed, m'lady."

"I'm here to help with your Jedi problem. This," Catra said, gesturing to Adora, "is my squad's commander. She'll be discussing tactics and arranging plans with your men. I'll handle the Jedi."

"Understood, m'lady. If you'd follow us, we'll show you our base of operations and I'll introduce you to the commandant."

Catra nodded and waved the guards forward. The two who had taken forward positions before moved to flank the officer and her escort while the other four arranged themselves around Catra and Adora. Catra lowered the volume on her helmet's output to speak just to Adora.

"Well-trained, huh?"

"I told you so," Adora shot back quietly. Her voice was metallic through the helmet, devoid of the warmth and character it usually had.

"We really gotta get those helmets better voice modulators."

“They’re supposed to sound like this, Catra. It’s more intimidating.”

“Oh so what, just because we’re on the job I don’t get to hear your voice?” Even through the helmet Catra could tell Adora rolled her eyes.

“You can’t just modify Imperial armor at will, Cat.”

“Whatever. You guys are boring.” Adora ignored that. Catra smiled underneath her own helmet.

They came to a stop in front of the central building in the complex soon after. “This is our meeting room and administrative building. I imagine much of your time will be spent here so I won’t delay; head on in,” the young officer said.

Again two guards went ahead. They gave the all clear and Catra followed them. The officer led them to a large door down the main hall and opened it into a room with several officers and advisors, gathered around a holo-table with a display of the planet’s surface.

The presiding officer looked up as the door opened. “Ah, this must be the agent sent by the Emperor. Welcome!”

Catra returned his greeting, then quickly cut her vocal amplifier. “Light, what information do they have on me?”

“Very little. The Emperor sent you to deal with the Jedi here, you are to be provided with any aid you require, and you’ve been sent under the codename ‘Stalker.’”

“They could’ve told me that,” Catra muttered.

“It was in the briefing.”

“Shut up, Light.” She keyed the amplifier back on. “Most of our coordination will be done through my guard’s officer. I’m just here to deal with the Jedi; how we get there is your duty.”

"Understood, m'lady. I presume the Ensign provided a good escort?"

"She did her job. Brief me on the situation."

The commandant walked her through the important notes quickly. "The Jedi was last sighted near this assumed rebel encampment," he said, pointing to a red dot in a small canyon. "We would have simply bombarded it, but the canyon walls make it near impossible for our ships to target it. The canyon mouth is a narrow choke point, but unless we can drive the rebels out of it it will only serve as a killing floor for our troops."

"Why can't you bombard it?" Adora asked.

"We have no way to confirm its exact location and we can't afford to blast the whole canyon. We've tried sending in teams to plant a beacon, but none have made it."

"Of course your stormtroopers haven't made it. They're big, loud and clumsy," Catra cut in. "I'll handle the beacon. Make sure your men are ready to spring a trap when the rebels run. I can separate the Jedi before the mouth of the canyon if you can make sure the rebels can't double back."

"Are you sure that's a good plan? The Emperor spoke highly of you, but taking on a Jedi alone is suicide."

"I've done it before, I'll do it again. I have my own advantages. Just be in position."

"Understood. I'll move my men into position at dawn and await your signal."

Catra snuck into the encampment overnight. It was lightly guarded; whether it was lack of men or overconfidence she wasn't sure. Getting in and out was effortless. The beacon was in place.

She waited until she received the signal from Adora that the trap was ready before remotely activating it.

Two minutes later, the first turbolasers rained down on the camp. Misses, but close enough to set off alarms. The next shot was close enough to get them moving, and it was then that Catra realized why the camp was practically unguarded.

"Adora, they're not rebels. They're civilians."

"What?" Adora's voice crackled in her helmet.

"Less than a third of them are even armed. These aren't rebels."

"Cat, it's too late. By the time orders are relayed they'll be dead. Assuming they even care."

Damn the Empire. "Move your squad to my location. We'll take out the soldiers and the Jedi ourselves and then get the refugees to safety."

"Safety? Catra, there's a reason they're hiding." Catra shook her head.

"They're safer as Imperial slaves than facing Imperial guns, Adora. I don't like it either."

"Fine. I'll tell the commandant to prepare for unarmed prisoners. We're on our way." The channel closed.

On your way isn't fast enough . Catra dropped down in front of the crowd. They were barely organized; soldiers in ratty uniforms patrolled the edges, trying to keep everyone together. It took a moment for them to realize Catra was there.

She maxed out her voice amplifier. "I'm not a stormtrooper," she called. "I just want the Jedi. Hand them over and nobody will get hurt."

One of the rebels stepped forward, defiant, but was cut off by a young man. “If I go with you, can you guarantee these people’s safety?”

“I can, but I’m not asking you to come with me. Step forward.” Hesitantly, he did so. She analyzed him; human, not from here. He wasn’t being sheltered as one of their own, he was trying to protect them. He was young and seemed inexperienced; he likely wasn’t a Knight. She drew her lightsaber.

“What are your terms?” he asked, drawing closer.

“My terms are your life for theirs.”

“And if I refuse?”

Catra sighed. “You die either way. But at the end of that canyon is an Imperial ambush primed to slaughter everyone here. Whether they have advance warning about the civilians or not depends on whether you die quietly.” It was a lie. The Imperials knew there were refugees, but she was stalling until Adora could reach her. This Jedi was too young to be so completely absorbed into their teachings to give his life without a fight, but it was still what he had been taught. Hopefully, it would give him pause long enough for-

A blaster bolt whizzed by her head, nailing one of the soldiers. Suddenly she was surrounded by Imperial Guardsmen; their cloaks were gone and their ceremonial spears had been replaced with each woman’s weapon of choice. “Adora, make sure the refugees aren’t harmed. I’ve got the Jedi.”

Catra drew her saber and leapt at him, their blades clashing as she landed behind him. The whole affair was swift; a Jedi apprentice was no match for her dueling skills and untrained rebels were no match for elite Imperial guards. The Jedi was slain quickly and cleanly and what few rebels survived were disarmed and taken as prisoners. The refugees were led down the canyon to the Imperial soldiers, where they were loaded onto transports.

“What’s gonna happen to them?” Adora asked.

“If they’re not a threat, they’ll be assisted into society. Some may remain here and work, some may be taken offworld,” the commandant answered.

“As slaves, you mean.” Catra’s helmet did nothing to dull the edge in her tone.

“Some, perhaps. Those we deem dangerous or overly sympathetic to the rebel cause. Most will be paid workers or find citizenship on other planets. I assure you, the Empire does not wish to make a habit of enslavement.”

“Yeah, sure. Job’s done; let’s get out of here,” Catra said, turning to walk away.

“She’s quite an interesting one, Captain.”

“She had a rough life.”

“The best always do, Captain. I do hope you keep her in line; would be a shame for the Emperor to lose such an asset.”

Adora didn’t respond, instead following Catra back to the ship.

Tension

Catra was back in her room, tucking the Jedi's lightsaber into her closet's hidden storage compartment. It joined several others: Starkiller's pair, her first saber, and three others taken from various contracts. She picked up her old blade, running her hands along the silver hilt.

Her adoptive father had given it to her when she first began displaying her force sensitivity. Apparently it was a relic, passed down from the Mandalorian Wars thousands of years ago. It had never felt right in her hand but it was still a memory of her clan, one she wasn't ready to get rid of.

The door slid open behind her. "Hey, Cat." Adora paused. "What's that?"

Catra put the saber away and closed the compartment, going back to removing her armor. "My old lightsaber."

"Is that the one?..."

She breathed in deep. "Yeah. It's the one I had when we were seventeen."

"Oh." Adora's voice was quiet, breathy. "I'm sorry, I should-"

"Let's not talk about it, okay?" Catra cut her off. "Did you need something?"

Adora was still silent for a moment. Catra turned to prompt her with a look, but froze at the sight of tears rolling down Adora's cheeks. "What's wrong?" she whispered.

There was no answer, Adora just launched herself forward and hugged her, burying her face in her neck. Catra hugged her on instinct, clutching her tightly.

"Talk to me, baby," she whispered, the words coming automatically, faster than Catra could think about them. She tensed when she realized, but Adora just hugged her tighter.

"I-I missed you," she eventually managed to say. "I missed you so much, Cat."

"I missed you too, Adora. It's okay now, I'm right here," she murmured back, stroking her hair gently. She slowly and gently pulled Adora over to the bed, leading her to sit down but not letting go. After a minute, she cupped Adora's chin and tilted her head up to look at her. "Let's get this armor off, okay? Then you can cry all you need."

Adora nodded and followed Catra as they stood back up. Slowly and carefully, Catra pulled the red plating off of her body. She led Adora to the closet and helped her put on a more comfortable set of clothes before laying her back down in bed. She finished removing her own armor and changing, then joined Adora. Despite the blonde's silence, she didn't cry; instead, she cuddled close to Catra and enjoyed her presence.

They were interrupted by Light after a few minutes. "Lady Catra, Hope is requesting orders."

Catra groaned, lifting her head from where it was buried in Adora's hair. "Tell them to take the ship into a high orbit and wait for me. And stay the hell away from that Star Destroyer."

"Understood." Light powered off again, leaving Catra and Adora alone again. She leaned down and pressed a kiss to Adora's cheek before speaking.

"We should get clean," she whispered. Adora groaned but nodded. "There's a shower right through that door. You go first, okay?"

"Come with me," Adora murmured back. Catra faltered, squeezing Adora's arm.

“You sure?” she asked. Her only response was a nod against her chest.

She took a deep breath, then stood, guiding Adora with her. She planted a kiss on Adora’s forehead before undressing them both, every movement still careful as if Adora was a fragile artwork. Taking Adora’s hands in her own, she led her to the bathroom and started the shower, waiting for the recycled water to warm up before stepping in. Adora followed her, squeezing into the small space against Catra.

“Can I wash your hair?” Catra whispered. Adora nodded again and Catra repositioned them so Adora was closer to the water. She grabbed the shampoo, pouring a healthy amount into her hands and gently began rubbing it into Adora’s hair. She massaged her scalp, using the pads of her fingertips to pull shuddering moans from Adora. “You’re so fucking tense,” she murmured. “Relax for me, I’ve got you.”

The only response she got was another groan as she rubbed the back of Adora’s head with her thumbs. Finally finishing, she planted a kiss between Adora’s shoulder blades and pulled her under the water. She continued her careful ministrations, rinsing the shampoo from her hair.

She let her hands drop to Adora’s shoulders and continued massaging. “I should’ve run a bath,” she muttered, working Adora’s shoulders and upper back. “I’m gonna wash you, okay? And try to get some of this tightness out,” she added, hoping she wasn’t going to overstep by offering.

Adora nodded, still struggling with words. So Catra set to work, washing and massaging her one step at a time. First, her back and shoulders, then her chest and belly, careful not to linger too long. She was thorough with Adora’s arms, spending extra time on her biceps and wrists. She carefully sat her on the edge of shower’s back edge, lifting each of her legs and giving them the same treatment. She carefully massaged her feet, washing them and looking lovingly up at Adora.

She washed herself much quicker, only basking in the hot water for a minute longer than was necessary. Adora's eyes burned into her back the whole time, prompting Catra to give her a soft smile over her shoulder. When she finished and turned off the shower, she dried Adora off with the same gentle reverence she had washed her with.

"Catra, I-" Catra cut her off, placing two fingers on her lips.

"Don't talk, Adora. Just relax. I've got you and I'm not letting go, okay?"

Empire

Catra ducked effortlessly under Adora's swing, lunging forward to strike at her ribs. Adora's second vibroblade batted the thrust away. They split for a moment, catching their breath and circling. Adora made the first move, feinting with her left hand and striking with her right, hoping to catch Catra off guard. She was ready, though, sweeping the blow away and stepping back in, every movement graceful. She ducked and spun under Adora's other blade, bringing her saber around and into her torso; a clean cut.

"Ow!" Adora squealed, stumbling back.

"Fuck, did I set it too high?" Catra jumped forward, looking at where the blade had landed.

Adora looked at her for a moment and started giggling. "No, it's fine. Just wasn't expecting it." She only laughed harder at Catra's glare.

"You worried me! I thought I hurt you!"

"You didn't, I promise. It just stings a bit," Adora assured her.

Catra looked doubtful, but nodded. "Can you go another round? I wanna try something."

"Yeah," Adora responded. "What is it?" Catra didn't answer at first, walking over to the equipment locker. She keyed in a specific code and a compartment slid open.

"How many hidden drawers do you have on this ship?" Adora asked, partially teasing. Catra gave her a dry look.

"I don't exactly operate above board, Adora. Half this ship is secret storage. And it's *not* a drawer," she teased back, sliding out a weapon rack. "I know you're used to using twin blades, but I've been watching the way you fight and I think you might do better with one." She pulled a gorgeous sword off the rack as she spoke.

It was inlaid with gold and a single gem in the crossguard. "I don't know where it's from, but the Mandalorians passed this down to me at some point. I understand if you don't want it, but-"

"It's perfect," Adora said, enthralled. "Can I try it?"

"Of course. It's probably pretty dull right now, so it should be safe." Catra handed it to her, watching the reverence she handled it with. "It's not fragile, Adora. It's a weapon." Adora ignored her, hefting the blade in her hand. She took a step back and gave it a practice swing. She was practically glowing. In fact, if Catra didn't know better, she'd say she *was* glowing.

Finally, Adora set herself. Catra reignited the training saber, settling into a guard stance. Adora made the first move, impatient as always. Catra parried and tried to riposte, an easy victory already laid out for her, but the blade swept back up immediately. Adora was striking again quickly, putting Catra on her back foot. She parried each blow but never had an opening to attack herself. She knew she could do this longer than Adora could, so she resolved to wait. She deflected everything Adora could throw at her but the blonde showed no sign of tiring; if anything, she became more precise and focused as the fight went on. Eventually, Catra was outright dodging, unable to match Adora's speed and strength.

After what felt like hours, Catra raised a hand to stop Adora. "We could do this all day, but eventually I'm gonna get too tired to do this and get hurt."

Adora cocked her head like she didn't understand. "I feel fine, Cat. How are you that tired?" She was teasing Catra, but Catra wasn't having it. She gestured to the clock.

"It's been an hour and you haven't relented at all. Wait a sec, did you get taller?" Catra asked suddenly, shaking herself off. When she opened her eyes, Adora was her normal height. *What the hell?*

"You okay, Cat? Do you need water?" Adora was worried, a hand on Catra's shoulder. "I can go get some right now, just stay here okay?"

"Adora, I'm fine. Just kinda tired, I promise. Though… Water sounds nice. I've been sweating like a bitch trying to keep up with you." Adora nodded, giving her one more worried look as she walked out of the training room to fetch some water.

It didn't escape Catra's notice that Adora wasn't sweating at all as she left. She looked at the sword Adora had left leaning by the door when she left, walking over to pick it up. She had always hated it; it was heavy and unwieldy, meant for hacking through armor instead of graceful dueling. But Adora had handled it like a rapier. She was pretty sure she had seen her using it one handed a few times, in fact.

The door slid open and Catra set the sword back down again quickly. She took the water from Adora with a "thank you" and drank it quickly. Adora was still giving her that worried puppy dog look the whole time.

"I promise I'm fine, Adora. That was just a hell of a workout." She smiled to emphasize her point.

"Okay, sorry. It's just… 'did you get taller'? I thought you started hallucinating." Catra shrugged.

"Maybe I did. Whatever it was, I'm fine now. I was probably just dehydrated," she said, pointing at her sweat-soaked top. Adora nodded.

"You should probably take a shower, actually. Before you start smelling."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Whatever, dummy. I've never smelled in my life."

"Yeah, so keep that record up and go get in the shower. We're almost to Coruscant, anyways," Adora said.

Catra wrinkled her nose at that. As nice as being off the ship sounded, they were only going to Coruscant because the Emperor had called them and he was… unsettling at best. "Fine," she muttered, still trying to put up a front of protest. "If you insist, *Princess* ."

"I do. Now go, shoo!" They were both giggling by the time Catra made it out. She cleared her throat and looked around at the guards, all of which were staring at her.

"What? Get back to what you were doing!" A couple of them shared looks with each other, but did as they were told. Catra showered quickly and walked back into her room to see Adora sitting on the bed, reading something on her handheld comm.

"Hey, Cat," she said, still distracted by the article. "How was your shower?"

"Good. Whatcha reading?" Adora looked up at that.

"Oh, just an article about what happened on Ryloth. 'Brave Mandalorian and Imperial Guards save hostages from dangerous rebels, Jedi.'" Adora started reading the article to Catra while she dressed. "'The citizens expressed their sincere gratitude to the Empire for their rescue. Many have offered their services to the mining operations on Ryloth's surface.' Cat, this is all wrong. Those people weren't hostages."

Catra shrugged. "The Empire controls the media. Did you think they would tell the public what really happened?" The shock on Adora's face answered for her. "Adora, did you really not know that none of the news the Empire touches is true? They control *everything* , and none of it can ever make them look bad."

"That can't be true. There have to be sources that tell the truth no matter what."

"Not for long. There are a few in the underworld that have been around for a while, but even they have to stay on their toes

to avoid Imperial raids. I've lost a few friends to the Empire for telling the truth."

Adora just stared, mouth agape. Her thoughts were running at a hundred miles an hour; she had always known that the news they received in the Academy and on duty was limited, but she had no idea the Empire really controlled *all* of it.

After a few moments of silence, she spoke. "Then why are you here? You obviously think the Empire is bad."

"Needed the money. All of my jobs were Imperial anyways. There aren't exactly private citizens that need force sensitives eliminated. Figured there was no harm in making it official." She said it flatly, like it was obvious. Maybe it should've been obvious; Catra was a mercenary, had been since she was a kid. Who her clients were didn't matter as long as they paid. Catra cut her thoughts off with a sigh as she finally finished pulling her shirt on. "Stop giving me that look. You're in the Imperial *military* . I'm just making sure I don't starve. How the hell did that happen, anyways?"

Adora looked away. Sure, she had spaced out, but that wasn't the *only* reason she was staring at Catra. "You left, there was nothing for me at home anymore. I caught a transport offworld and got recruited while I was switching to a new one. I made my way through the Academy and got picked for a chance at being a Guardsman, so I took it. I never saw duty outside of the Emperor's throne room." She shrugged, still staring at the floor. "I heard about you, you know."

"You did?"

"Yeah. I didn't know it was *you* , at least not for certain, but stories of a Jedi hunter taking bounties for the Empire spread pretty quickly. Fit your description, so I guessed it was you." They were quiet for a minute. "Do you think we're doing the right thing?"

"What do you mean?"

"Working for the Empire. I was so sure when I joined that it was a good idea, but…"

"But now you know the truth about them? Adora, I don't have answers for you. Whether you're doing the right thing is up to you."

"And what about you?"

Catra scoffed. "The right thing is whatever pays for food and ship upkeep. I can't afford to worry about it beyond that."

Light powered on. "Hope wishes to inform you that we are approaching Coruscant; we will be making our final approach in fifteen minutes."

"Tell him I'll be in the cockpit in a second," Catra said.

"Understood." Light powered off again.

"You coming, Adora?" Catra reached out her hand.

"Yeah, I'll be right behind you," she replied, not looking up. Catra stood there a moment longer, then turned and left. Adora cried again after the door closed.

Landing was easy enough and Sparkles brought them down gently outside of the Emperor's palace. The guards provided an escort to the throne room, but Adora didn't come. The others remained outside, waiting with the guards on duty.

"Ah, the hunter returns," the Emperor said as she walked in. To his right stood a tall figure in dark armor; Vader.

Catra was already impatient and on edge. "What do you want? If you have a mission you can get in contact with me instead of

dragging me across the galaxy." She could *feel* the way Vader bristled at her tone, but the Emperor simply smiled beneath his hood.

"This requires your presence, I assure you. Bring out the prisoner." Two guards nodded and left, returning after a few minutes with a bound man between them. A strange, lizard-like creature hung from a pack on his back. He looked up and Catra recognized him. *Starkiller* . Again she felt Vader bristle. "Yes, Lord Vader. Your secret apprentice, reduced to little more than a broken prisoner."

"Well, isn't this some juicy drama. Why the hell am I here?" Catra interrupted.

Palpatine turned back to her. "Kill him." She froze. "Strike the poor boy down. He serves no purpose."

She considered for a moment. *They better pay extra for this.* She drew her lightsaber and walked to Starkiller. As soon as she got close, everything started to feel weird. Like something was missing. Quickly she realized that something was dampening her connection to the force.

"Yes, hunter," the Emperor said, "we did indeed find our own way of cutting Jedi off from the force. Not as graceful as yours, perhaps, but it works well enough."

"Do you want him dead or not?" Catra shot back. She was tired of games.

"Kill him," came the reply.

The blow was quick, painless. The saber left a deep gash across his chest; his body slumped limply to the ground. She moved away and felt her connection to the force return.

"Can I leave now?"

"Perhaps. Lord Vader, do you believe she should be allowed to leave?" Pure rage poured off of Vader.

"If you're gonna try and kill me then know you'll lose," Catra growled. "Let me walk out of here, now."

"Your anger is powerful, hunter. As is my apprentice's. But both of you still have use in my service; you may leave, hunter."

Catra didn't bother responding. She stormed out of the door and waved her guards into formation behind her. Adora was waiting at the top of the ship's ramp, still in casual clothes. She followed Catra into her room.

"What's wrong?" she asked, trying to close the distance and hug Catra, but she pulled away.

"The Emperor tried to sic his fucking pet on me," Catra answered angrily.

"You mean?-"

"Yeah, fucking Vader. *Apparently* Starkiller was his apprentice or some shit, so he was pretty fucking pissed that I captured him and then the Emperor had me execute him."

"And you *did it* ?"

"Of course I did it, Adora! What the hell was I *supposed* to do?"

She faltered. That wasn't something she had an answer for, but something about the situation felt wrong. "I don't know," she admitted after a moment.

"Well I don't either! He's fucking *playing* with me, Adora. He didn't even give us a new mission!" Adora tried to step close again and Catra let her this time. She wrapped her in a tight hug and sat her down on the bed. She didn't know what to say, but she

knew how to hold Catra while she calmed down so she did, for nearly half an hour.

"Thanks, Adora," Catra whispered into her shoulder eventually.

"Of course, Cat. Anything for you," she whispered back.

"I'm tired as fuck."

"Me too. Bedtime?" Catra nodded, nuzzling further into her shoulder. "You need help changing?" Catra nodded again.

Adora stripped her and found more comfortable clothes for her, the same way she had several times for Adora already. After getting her situated in bed, she changed and climbed in too.

"Light," Catra called sleepily. "Lights out."

"Understood. Sleep well, Lady Catra." The lights went off and Catra snuggled close to Adora.

"Goodnight, Cat," she murmured, kissing her head. She waited for a response, but Catra was already asleep. Adora smiled and closed her eyes, falling asleep quickly too.

She didn't remember her dreams well when she woke up, but she remembered a feeling of dread and the need to *do* something. Something about a hero and a sword. Something about *her* .

Catra took her out to a Coruscant restaurant for breakfast. It was fancy and expensive, but good. Apparently the Empire had paid handsomely for the Ryloth job, so Catra covered their food without a second thought. Adora didn't mention the dreams. She figured they were just weird nightmares, after all. It wouldn't be the first time.

"Catra?"

"Yeah, what's up?"

"What are we?"

Catra didn't answer; Adora could've sworn she stopped breathing entirely.

"What do you want us to be?"

A thousand answers raced through her head. *I want to be your everything, I want to marry you, I want to be with you every day of my life and never spend a second without you* . All that came out was, "If you're okay with it, I'd like to be your girlfriend again." It was hesitant, careful. They were close again but that didn't mean Catra was ready-

"Yes. Yeah. I'd like that, Adora." Catra was looking at her tenderly now.

"Then… Girlfriends?" It wasn't enough, it wasn't the promise she wanted but she could settle.

"Girlfriends." Catra took her hand. "I love you, Adora."

It took everything to not cry. "I love you too, Catra," she choked out. "Can we go back to the ship?"

Catra smiled. "Actually, I have something I want to show you. I can hail a taxi if you're ready to go."

Adora nodded; she wasn't exactly up to being in public any longer, but if it meant being with Catra she could handle it. She could handle anything with Catra.

Krayts and Devils

The taxi ride was in comfortable silence. Catra never let go of Adora's hand. They stopped outside one of the city-planet's clusters of high-rises; the buildings were grand and expensive, only available to the Empire's upper class. Catra led Adora out of the taxi and into one of the buildings. The lobby was as ornate as the outside.

"Cat, what's going on?" Adora whispered as she was tugged along.

"Shh. You'll understand in a minute. Close your eyes and stay close to me," Catra whispered back. Adora hesitantly did as she was told, letting Catra guide her through the mostly empty lobby.

Catra pulled her into an elevator and punched in the floor number she needed, making sure Adora still didn't look. The elevator ride was long enough for Adora to guess where they were going, but she gave no indication if she had figured out Catra's plan. She was shifting restlessly by the time the doors opened.

After another few seconds of pulling, Catra came to a stop. "Okay. Open," she said, excitement tinging her voice. Adora's eyes slowly blinked open and she gasped. In front of her was a giant window and below her… Below her the city sprawled for miles. They must've been a hundred floors up. She looked at Catra, mouth agape. Catra just took her hands again and smiled.

"Penthouse. I figured we'd be living out of the ship or wherever we were staying on jobs, but turns out the Empire is paying me a fee to stay available. It's more than enough to afford keeping this place reserved." Adora still didn't speak, so Catra continued. "I want to share it with you, Adora. Somewhere to really call our own while we're here."

Finally Adora answered her. “Cat, I can’t.” She fought to keep her rising emotions out of her voice and failed. Immediately Catra’s shoulders fell, her face settling into that worried look Adora knew so well. Her own doubts and thoughts raced through her head. Had she overstepped? Was this too much too fast? Adora must’ve noticed because she squeezed Catra’s hands. “It’s not that I don’t want to, I really do. But us being involved is risky as is. If the Empire found out I was living with you here…” she trailed off. She didn’t know exactly what would happen, but it wouldn’t be good.

Emotions warred on Catra’s face, emotions Adora recognized. She was fighting the desire to say she didn’t care, to throw caution to the wind and to hell with the Empire or anyone else who came between them. It was the same thing she had done six years ago before the two shared their first secret kiss. It had been charming then, when it was the only excitement in Adora’s life. But eventually Catra sighed.

“I understand. I won’t push you, Adora,” she said, her voice level. She couldn’t risk pushing Adora away by fighting her now, not when she just got her back. Adora sent her a silent thank you, her heart bare in her eyes. “Will you at least stay today?” Catra wasn’t sure if she should ask, but her need to be with Adora won out this time.

Adora nodded. “Today,” she repeated, making the boundary clear. They tried to make the most of it, cuddling for the whole day, but Catra’s heart wasn’t in it. She hadn’t intended on bringing Adora here when she confirmed her reservation the night before, but after that morning the place felt empty and cold knowing she would be here alone. She didn’t go with Adora to the lobby when she left, seeing her out at the apartment’s door instead. It wasn’t dark yet, but she fell into bed anyways as soon as Adora was gone. She didn’t even change before she passed out.

It was before dawn when she woke up. She stared out the window for a while after climbing out of bed and changing, mentally mapping the city beneath her. She had spent time in the lower levels under these towers when she was young; it was part of the reason she had picked them. Part of her swore she felt the thrumm of machinery even this high up, the heart of the planet sending a gentle rumble through the ground at her feet. She knew she couldn't, of course. The machines were barely audible from where she had stayed, much less from this penthouse. They had soothed her in her childhood, masking some of the less pleasant noises from her sensitive ears. Now, though, the only noises she wanted blocked out were the ones coming from inside her own head.

Before she even asked, she knew Adora would say no. They had just formally gotten back together that morning, after all. They may have been living together on the ship but that was a necessity; actively making the choice was a much bigger step. Catra had spent the entire day silently cursing herself out for the mistake.

Eventually she got up the courage to check her comm. A message from Adora, like she expected.

Hey, Cat. I hope you're settling into your place alright. I'm sorry about yesterday. Can we meet up for lunch?

Adora was sorry for yesterday? It was Catra's fault, wasn't it? Maybe this was just Adora, taking the blame even when she shouldn't.

It's not your fault, Adora. Lunch sounds great. Meet here or at the ship?

The response was quick.

I'll meet you at your place. Less likely for the Empire to be keeping an eye on it.

How's it feel to be sneaking around, soldier?

Like we're teenagers again. Be there soon?

I'll be waiting. After a moment of consideration, Catra added a heart to the message. Adora didn't seem upset, so maybe she hadn't overstepped as badly as she thought.

She met Adora at the front door of the building. She had opted for a simple, all-black outfit with a few pieces of gold jewelry for flair. A black jacket rested over a form fitting black shirt with a pair of black pants hugging her legs. On her right hand she wore two gold rings and she had a single gold chain around her neck.

Adora climbed out of her taxi in a red jacket and white shirt. It looked like an Imperial regulation uniform. Her face lit up when she saw Catra.

"Hey!" Adora called, sprinting up to her and hugging her. "How was last night? Did you get settled in okay?"

"Yeah, it was fine. Weird at first, but fine," Catra responded. She didn't mention that she had trouble getting to sleep after having to sleep alone for the first time since she and Adora had reunited, or how long she had spent stressing over already ruining their relationship again. "How are you?"

"I missed you," Adora said, kissing her on the forehead. "It felt weird not having you in bed with me." She paused for a second, her eyes going wide. "Oh um, I'm uh, sorry, I shouldn't have-"

Catra interrupted her by throwing her arms around her neck and pulling her close, nuzzling against her throat. "I missed you too, Adora," she murmured, planting a kiss under the blonde's jaw. "Come on, let's go eat." Pulling back, she added, "I haven't even *looked* at food today."

Adora nodded. "Where do you want to go?"

"Are you telling me you invited me to lunch and didn't have somewhere in mind?" Catra said, crossing her arms.

“I uh, wasn’t sure what you’d like so I thought I should ask,” Adora muttered, embarrassed.

“Get in the taxi, dummy. You’re lucky I planned ahead.”

Adora did as she was told, climbing back in the taxi with a sheepish look. Catra followed her, taking her hand as she sat down. She directed the droid pilot to one of the nearby restaurants she had always wanted to eat at when she was a kid and provided the credits for the fare. They rode in silence as Catra stared at Adora. Eventually, she looked over.

“What? Is something on my face?” She started wiping at her face, trying to find the phantom mess. Catra giggled at her and grabbed her wrists.

“Kiss me, dummy,” she said, smiling. She pulled Adora in, guiding her into a gentle kiss. Catra held her there for a moment after the taxi came to a stop, soaking in the warmth of her girlfriend for as long as possible. She was still smiling when she finally broke the kiss. “Come on.”

The two left the taxi, Catra reluctantly letting go of Adora’s hand as they did so. Once inside it was at least mostly safe for them to show affection, but out in the open was still risky. They had taken the chance to greet each other outside of Catra’s apartment but they couldn’t risk more.

The restaurant Catra had picked out was riding the fine line between trashy and casually classy. People loitered outside, some looking rougher than others. A fairly steady stream of clients made their way in and out. The building was in the shadow of some of the taller ones around it, but wasn’t quite in the underlevels of Coruscant.

“Stay close to me,” Catra whispered into Adora’s ear. “It can get kinda rough around here, but I still have some connections whose names carry weight.”

"Aren't I supposed to protect you?" Adora teased, only receiving a deadly serious look in return.

"Adora, I know you're trying to be funny but you don't know this city like I do. One wrong move and we're in trouble, you understand?" There was a gentle firmness to her voice; she was serious, but not angry at Adora. More like she was worried. Adora nodded and followed Catra, close but still just behind her.

Catra played with the signet ring she wore on her index finger. It was a gift from a dear friend on Coruscant, and one with lots of pull in the planet's underworld. At least, he did four years before, when he gave the ring to her. She hadn't spoken to him since. He had ruled as a gang leader for most of her life, but four years was still a long time on a planet like this. Thankfully, none of the ruffians around the entrance messed with them. She recognized some of their attire, marking them as members of different gangs. None of them seemed particularly dangerous; no off-world organizations or major syndicates made an appearance. Still, she wanted to avoid a confrontation.

Unfortunately, her wish wouldn't be granted. Just before they got to the door, a group of thugs muscled out of it. They were armed, as was usual for this area, and drunk, which was also usual. As soon as they laid eyes on Catra and Adora, they were interested. Despite both of them being fit, two women were still considered easy targets for a mugging.

Why the fuck did I wear gold? Catra wondered as she came to a stop. The leader of the four stepped forward.

"W'at do we 'ave 'ere?" he said. "I think you'se should empty your pockets. My boys and I have a tab to pay."

"Back off," Catra snarled, flashing the signet ring. "I'm with the Golden Krayts."

The other gang members that had gathered around to watch shifted uncomfortably. The Krayts were still dominant, apparently.

But the thug just laughed.

"Is 'at s'posed to scare us? The Krayts won't matter much longer!"

Fuck . Catra had just walked headfirst into a war between the Krayts and whoever these guys were with. "Adora," she whispered. "Wait by the taxi. This'll only take a minute."

"Cat-"

" *Go* , Adora. I'll catch up with you, I promise. We can't have an Imperial officer getting involved in a brawl."

That seemed to make it click and Adora backed off. Catra could tell from the way she tensed and started taking her jacket off as she left that she was ready to jump in and help if needed.

With that taken care of, Catra turned back to the thugs. She stripped her own jacket off and grinned, baring her teeth. "I take it you boys don't know who I am?"

"Why the 'ell should we?" Catra's jacket hit the ground with a *clang!* Her lightsaber rattled around for a moment in one of the pockets.

"No particular reason," she said, running forward and vaulting over his head. She swept her leg back and brought it against the side of his knee with a sharp *crack!* , then turned and leapt around her second target. Using his throat as leverage, she pulled him down into a chokehold. The two still standing yanked out their vibroblades. Keeping one arm around her victim's neck, Catra extended her hand and called her lightsaber to her from her jacket.

The first thug didn't realize what was happening before his strike was intercepted and his hand was cut clean off. His partner faltered as the dismembered hand dropped to the ground. She looked from the hand up to the lightsaber that had taken it.

“Recognize me now?” Catra growled. The thug dropped her vibroblade. Their leader had gotten back to his feet now and turned to look at them. Catra turned her glare to him. “It’s one thing to fuck with a Golden Krayt. It’s another thing to fuck with a Mandalorian. Unfortunately for you, I’m *both* . Now, the three of you are gonna disarm, you’re gonna go apologize to the owner of this *fine establishment* for the disruption, then you’re gonna leave and never show your goddamn faces on this planet again. *Are we clear?* ”

The two thugs with vibroblades immediately listened, dropping their spare weapons and backing away quickly. Their leader was determined to be stubborn, though.

“And if I don’t?” he asked defiantly.

“You and your friend here,” she said, gesturing at the thug she was still choking, “die at the end of my lightsaber. Your choice.”

She was glad he was a human; watching the color drain from his face was amusing. He led the other two thugs into the restaurant, where she could only assume they were making up for their disturbance. Finally, she released the one she was holding.

He was an Iktochi; one of his horns was broken off and he stood a full head taller than Catra. He was burly and wore the same unfamiliar marked jacket as the other three.

“You’re gonna tell me what the *hell* is going on,” Catra demanded. He looked at her, confused, and she sighed. “I’ve been off-world for a while. Who the hell are you and what makes you think you shouldn’t be afraid of the Krayts?”

He spoke eventually, staring at her in awe. “We’re the Canyon Devils. We’re the strongest gang on Coruscant and starting here, we’re gonna wipe out the Krayts!” He paused when he saw Catra’s glare. “Uh, I mean…”

“If you think you stand a chance against the Krayts you’re *delusional* ,” Catra spat out. “They’ve ruled this section of the

underworld for twenty years and for good fucking reason."

"The Devils have support. The Krayts don't stand a chance once we get started."

"What kind of support?" Catra asked, leveling her lightsaber at her throat.

He scoffed. "As if I'd know details like that. Just know your time is almost at an end on this planet!" He was more confident now; Catra didn't like that. With a flick of her saber and a twist of her other wrist, she cut off his other horn and drove it point first into his thigh.

"Something to remember me by," she growled. "Get the fuck out of here."

He stumbled backwards and ran off, not even waiting for his companions. Adora made her way back to Catra, her red jacket back on. Catra picked her own jacket back up and put it on, but clipped her lightsaber to her belt instead of putting it in a pocket.

"That was impressive," Adora said, smirking. Catra walked inside without responding, marching up to the reception desk where the other three thugs were uncomfortably getting ready to leave.

"How much for damages?" Catra growled.

The woman at the desk glanced at the man standing to the side, presumably the owner. He stepped over to speak to Catra directly.

"I take it you're the woman who dealt with these three?" he asked, gesturing dismissively at the thugs.

"Yeah. How much do I owe you?" she said impatiently.

"Dear, you've caused no damages. If anything, that fight was beneficial." Catra looked at him quizzically and he leaned in. "Ever since the new gangs moved in, we've had less customers. A

powerful display of the Golden Krayts' presence is exactly the kind of thing we needed," he whispered.

Catra's eyes widened a little and she nodded. "I understand."

"Good! In fact, I'd like to offer you and your friend a meal, on the house! I'll have a waitress show you to a table and you can order at your earliest desire."

Catra just nodded again and followed the waitress, motioning for Adora to come with her. As soon as they were seated she pulled out her comm and keyed in a call she hadn't made in a long time.

It took a moment for the line to come alive. A hologram of a slender figure in their late middle-ages hovered above the comm as Catra set it down.

"My favorite kitty! It's been a long time since we've talked! How are you?" Their voice was smooth and elegant, even over the poor connection.

"Hey, Double Trouble. I don't have time for pleasantries. When's the earliest we can meet?" They froze at Catra's question.

"I can meet you right now. Where are you?"

"You know that one restaurant? The one I always wanted to try as a kid? I'm there with my girlfriend. Staff is friendly; they trust the Krayts. Get here quick."

Double Trouble nodded silently, then closed the channel. Adora raised an eyebrow at Catra.

"They lead the Golden Krayts, have since I was a kid. Krayts kept me safe when I was young, made sure I had food and shelter when I was struggling. In exchange, I stole shit for them."

"What kind of 'shit?'" Adora asked. Catra shrugged.

“Credits. Valuables. Whatever I could get out of people’s pockets, really. They weren’t picky. Double Trouble always had a soft spot for me. I came back to Coruscant for a bit four years ago, chasing some Jedi. Met them looking for leads and promised to rep the Krayts when I could in exchange for his help. Being under their protection is just a bonus to that.”

Their food arrived before Adora could continue their questioning. They were halfway through their meals, making small talk, when Double Trouble showed up. They were alone.

“Hey, kitty,” they said, prompting Catra to roll her eyes. Adora got a better look at them; she couldn’t place the species, but they were reptilian. Their movements and figure practically *oozed* grace and something more sinister.

“Start talking. Who are the Canyon Devils and what do you know about them?” Catra said, gesturing for Double Trouble to sit at the end of the table.

“Not much, kitten,” Double Trouble sighed. “They showed up a few months ago and started causing problems. They’ve already run my boys out of a few subsectors, this one included. I heard about what happened, by the way. That fight gave us enough momentum to start moving patrols back in and resume old protectorates, this place included.”

Catra grunted assent. “Yeah, you’re welcome. One of the thugs said they had some kind of support, but refused to tell me what. You’ve gotta have some suspicions, at least.”

Double Trouble sighed again. “The only options I’ve managed to settle on are Black Sun or the Empire. Either way, very bad news for us.” They noticed the way Adora tensed and tilted their head at her. “You must be the aforementioned girlfriend. Ponytail, carefully maintained physique, that *outfit* … Kitten, don’t tell me you’re sleeping with an *Imperial soldier!* ” Their voice fell to a conspiratorial whisper, a smile playing at their lips.

“Shut up. Stay out of my personal life, Dee,” Catra hissed back.

“Ooh, touched a sore spot? Or maybe you’re keeping secrets from me…” Double Trouble trailed off, staring at Catra. “What is it?”

The two girls shared a glance before Catra looked back to Double Trouble. “I’m working for the Empire, Dee.” They gasped. “Shut up. It’s not like I’m a soldier or anything, they just have me on as a retainer for hunting Jedi.”

“That doesn’t explain why you’re here with one of their soldiers, kitty,” Double Trouble prodded.

Catra sighed. “Adora was assigned as one of my personal guards. There isn’t exactly enough space for a full squad on my ship, so we had to stay in the same room while we were on assignment and one thing led to another.”

Double Trouble’s calm facade dropped as they turned to look at Adora. “ *The* Adora? I’ve heard *so much* about you! My poor kitty’s first heartbreak.” They put on a theatrical frown before smiling at her. “And here you are, back together. Soulmates, truly.”

“Shut *up* , Dee,” Catra snarled.

“Wait, you *know* about me?” Adora asked, shocked.

“Of course I do!” Double Trouble answered. “Catra wouldn’t stop talking about you last time we met. The ethereal blonde from a distant planet, caught on the opposite side of a war? A tragic love story if I’ve ever heard one.”

Adora was staring at Catra. Obviously she had said that she had always loved Adora, but something about hearing how much she still talked about her afterwards settled into her heart differently.

“Oh, she was absolutely torn up over you and it had been a full year! She had just gotten her first ship and all she could talk about was how empty it felt without you in it. Her words, not mine,” Double Trouble continued.

“Dee!” Catra interrupted. “Canyon Devils. Black Sun. Empire. This is important. Focus.”

Double Trouble pouted. “Oh, fine, kitty. Like I was saying, the equipment and funding available to them is on a level only those two could pull off. If it’s Black Sun, we can hold out for as long as possible and make the Golden Krayts a legendary name in Coruscant history.”

“And if it’s the Empire?” Catra asked.

“If it’s the Empire, kitten, our best option is to give up now. The first thing we teach our patrols is that no matter how tough they are, they don’t mess with Imperials. It’s the fast track to prison or death. If they decided they’re tired of letting us run things down here, then there’s nothing we can do about it.”

“You can’t just give up, Dee. This is your turf!”

Double Trouble smiled. “I don’t plan to, kitten. But I can’t risk my whole gang for my pride. It’s a moot point until we know more, anyways. If we’re lucky, I’m wrong and just missed the movements leading up to their initial appearance.”

“I’ll find out,” Adora whispered. Catra’s eyes snapped to her. “I'm still assigned to Coruscant, technically. I have the authority to ask those questions and get answers.”

“Authority?” Double Trouble questioned.

Adora looked at them. “I’m not just a soldier. I’m a commander of the Imperial Guard. When I ask for information, I get it.”

“Ask around, Adora,” Catra said. “We need everything we can get if we’re gonna take these guys down.”

“Kitty, did you not hear me?” Double Trouble said. “We can’t take them down. We need to prepare for the worst.”

Catra stood and stared down at them, fire in her eyes. “You didn’t have me when you made those calculations. I don’t care who’s behind them; they’re fucking with my home and I’ll make them pay.”

War

Adora wasn't kidding about getting what she asked for; two days after their meeting with Dee, she received a partial report on Imperial involvement in the Canyon Devils' bid for dominance. The gang wasn't formed by the Empire, but its growth was entirely due to Imperial funding. The report also mentioned that several Imperial instructors were provided to the gang to train their members, though the names of the instructors were redacted.

"Does it say why the Empire is getting involved?" Catra asked, pouring both of them another cup of coffee. Adora had spent the previous day and now most of the night at Catra's apartment, waiting for and then looking over the report while they planned out a strategy. Dee had spent part of the evening working with them via holo-call, but they had other priorities to attend to.

"The Krayts are becoming a threat, apparently. Their total dominance over Coruscant's underworld got some important people worried," Adora responded, graciously taking the cup of coffee. "It says they put the plan in motion months before the Devils even showed up, so as soon as they did the Empire jumped at the chance."

"So, fine. The Empire may be funding them and training them, but they're not fighting for them. That means we have a chance." Catra pulled up her commlink again and messaged Dee, summarizing what they had missed.

"Maybe. The Empire doesn't like it when people interfere in their plans, Cat. If we make things difficult for them, they might step up their support. Imperial-trained gang members are beatable, but if they start sending in stormtroopers it's over."

Catra wasn't going to be dissuaded. "We can handle it. We just have to outsmart them and nobody knows how to out-strategize unbeatable odds like Dee does. They've owned this planet's guts since before the Empire was here; they won't give it up now."

Adora nodded, unconvinced but willing to follow Catra's lead. "That's assuming Double Trouble is willing to risk it in the first place, though."

"Dee'll do it. We just have to make sure they have our support," Catra said, checking her comm to see if Dee had actually confirmed exactly that. Nothing yet, but even the summarized info was a lot to look over so Catra wasn't surprised. "Adora, I know you're worried. I'm not going to ask you to stay and fight if you don't want to, but the Krayts were my family as a kid. I have to help them."

"I'll stand with you, Cat. We'll be fine as long as we have each other, right?"

"Promise?" Catra asked.

"Promise." Adora smiled gently at her.

Dee started their plans the following morning. Over the next week, the Krayts were geared up and moved into position for an all-out war. Scouts gathered every piece of intel they could on the movements of the Canyon Devils and patrols were reinforced across the board. Dee and Catra called in some favors to have high-grade equipment delivered as fast as possible, but they'd still have to make do for at least three weeks.

Catra and Adora personally led patrols and raids in high-danger areas; in two weeks, more than a dozen Canyon Devil checkpoints were captured or destroyed, restoring Krayt control in seven key sectors.

Catra chose to leave her lightsaber behind, instead demonstrating her skill with a blaster rifle and electrostaff to more effectively deal with the Devils' shock troops. Whispers of a Mandalorian fighting alongside the Golden Krayts began spreading, leading more and more smaller gangs to pledge

themselves to her. Dee handled the negotiations and strategizing, but Catra became the gang's figurehead.

Once the heavy equipment they had requested arrived, the war ramped up. Tanks and old Republic scout walkers were repainted in Krayt colors and sent to pacify and patrol heavily defended locations, heavy weapons units locked down checkpoints with ease, and demolitions squads dismantled fortified locations. Of the 28 primary sectors Dee had outlined as important territory, 20 were firmly under Krayt control by the next month and four more were tentatively theirs. The last four were the Devils' base of operations; together, practically a fortress. Multiple levels of walls, manned by sentry turrets, artillery, and enforcers with heavy blasters, stood between them and the outside world.

The Krayts began to settle in for a long siege, but were interrupted three weeks in by Imperial forces. As Adora had predicted, the Empire didn't take kindly to their plans being disrupted. Stormtrooper squads supported by swoop bikes with laser cannons tore holes through the siege line, forcing them to retreat. With Imperial support, the Devils managed to push the Krayts back.

Now, four months into the war, the gangs were at an impasse. Imperial forces had lessened, seemingly satisfied with preventing the defeat of their chosen group, but didn't leave entirely. Most Devil patrols were accompanied by small stormtrooper squads and major assaults still had Imperial support.

It was late in the afternoon when Catra got an urgent message from Dee, asking her and Adora to meet at the Krayts' headquarters. She left immediately, calling Adora and telling her to meet them there.

Dee stood at the strategy room's main holotable, barking orders to reinforce certain areas and rearrange squads. They looked up as the door slid open.

“Cat, Adora, thank the force you’re here. We have a problem,” they said, swiping at the holotable to pull up the display they needed.

“What kind of problem, Dee?” Catra demanded, stepping up to the table. Adora followed beside her, analyzing the display in front of her.

“An Imperial transport landed in sector 7 this morning. Offloaded a full legion of stormtroopers and set up a checkpoint.”

“Okay? The Krayts can handle it, it wouldn’t be the first time,” Catra said. “Why are we here?”

Dee looked at her. “They have a regiment of AT-STs and an AT-AT. I need you to get into that checkpoint, sabotage those walkers, and shut off their communications. Otherwise my men don’t stand a chance.”

“How are we supposed to do that?” Adora asked, speaking for the first time.

“I’m sending you with one of our demolitions experts and a slicer. Get them in, keep them safe, and get them out. Then my men can storm the checkpoint under your command,” they answered, pulling up a map of the area. “My scouts found a gap in their surveillance here. It’s small, but it’s our only shot.”

Catra nodded. “We’ll handle it.”

Adora didn’t have time to argue. They were given quick introductions to the demo expert, a Twi’lek woman named Ayy, and the slicer, a Sullustan named Fubb, then hustled out to one of the Krayts’ speeders to travel to sector 7. The ride was quick and quiet. Catra cleaned her blaster in silence while Ayy double-checked her equipment. Adora watched Coruscant race by through the windows. Fubb chattered to himself quietly while he fiddled with some piece of tech from his bag.

“Checkpoint” was a loose term for the Imperial encampment. Mechanized walls reinforced with ray shielding surrounded it. Two AT-STs patrolled the perimeter, floodlights chasing away the shadows of Coruscant’s lower levels.

Crouched in the shadows, Catra started issuing orders. “Once we get in, Ayy and Adora split off to set the charges on the AT-STs and the AT-AT. I’ll take Fubb to shut down their communications. If we’re both done at the same time, we meet at the escape point. If I’m not there, send Ayy ahead and come to the comms station. If I get there first, I’ll send Fubb out and come meet you, okay Adora?”

Adora nodded. “Understood. Everyone ready?” At the affirmative nods, the four started sneaking towards the camp. Getting in was difficult, but Dee was right about the gap in surveillance. Once in, the two pairs separated. Fubb was fairly adept at avoiding the stormtroopers and Catra was practically a ghost. Using the vibroknife mounted to her armor’s left wrist, Catra silently dispatched the guards at the comm station and took up a position overseeing the area while Fubb set to work slicing into the Imperial system.

He had been working at it for over twenty minutes when Adora got back. “What’s taking so long?” Catra hissed, roughly translating the answer as “stronger security than expected.”

“Cat, we have to go,” Adora said as the gate opened. Her eyes were wide.

“We’re not done. Get in here before someone sees you,” Catra whispered back.

Adora did as she was told, looking down at Fubb struggling with the computer. “What’s taking so long?” she asked.

Fubb chattered back at her, exasperated. Adora tilted her head quizzically.

"He said it's tougher security than he expected," Catra translated for her. Adora looked up at her and quirked an eyebrow. "Sullustans are common in this line of work and they don't speak Basic," she said, shrugging. Fubb made an affirmative chatter, then an excited one. "He's got it," Catra said.

"Good, because we *have* to go," Adora said, remembering why she came here.

"What's wrong, Adora? Nobody's seen us, we have the time we need."

"These aren't just stormtroopers, Cat." Adora took a deep breath. "This is the 501st. Vader's Fist."

Fubb froze, as did Catra. He chattered nervously and Catra took a shuddery breath. "It's fine," she said, unconvincingly. "Vader's not *here* , I'd be able to tell if he was."

"Yeah, but that doesn't make it *not* one of the most elite legions in the Empire," Adora shot back.

"Then we don't get seen. Simple. Once those walkers are gone even the 501st won't be able to stop the army Dee has out there." Fubb chattered and made a noise in the back of his throat. "Shut up. We have *tanks* . They have, what?"

"The most hardcore training in the Empire, years of experience dating back to the Clone Wars, and a direct line to the single most dangerous man in the galaxy," Adora supplied.

"Be *quiet* , Adora. Once we cut these comms, their only advantage is gone. All the training in the world doesn't make you invincible to blaster fire." As if on cue, Fubb chattered triumphantly. "Finally! Let's get out of here," Catra exclaimed. Adora nodded.

The three made their way to the exit as fast as they could. They slipped out the same way they came in, where Ayy was

waiting. It was clear by the expression on her face that Adora had already told her about this being the 501st.

"We get back to our troops then blow the charges, got it?" Catra said, already on the move. The other three followed her; they made it back with no issues.

"That was too easy," Ayy muttered as soon as they were safe. Fubb chattered something about how much harder his job was at her, which quickly devolved into an argument that Catra tuned out.

"You in charge?" she snapped at one of the men, a human. He nodded, then saluted when he realized who she was. "Everything's in position except you. I want you to form up your assault lines. At twilight, we set off the charges and attack, got it?"

"Understood!"

"Good."

Now they just had to wait. Twilight in Coruscant's underbelly was much darker than on the surface, otherwise she would've waited until night. The gang formed up for a three-pronged attack; Catra assigned the commander she had spoken to to the left flank and Adora to the right. She led the center. Her helmet automatically brightened the scene she was taking in and her rifle's infrared sights allowed her to track the movements of patrols inside of and around the camp.

"T-5," she said. Adora and the commander transmitted their affirmatives. "Ayy? You ready with those charges?"

"On your command," Ayy responded.

Catra waited. Four minutes… three minutes… two minutes… one minute… thirty seconds… fifteen seconds.

"Now, Ayy! All forces charge! Demo squads, target the two walkers outside the camp!" Catra didn't wait for responses, raising her blaster and firing off a series of shots as explosions rose from inside the camp. Three stormtroopers dropped as her bolts found their targets. She jumped the barricade they were behind and advanced slowly, continuing to pick off targets from range. Rockets launched from the right flank, tearing an AT-ST to shreds and blowing through a wall.

Catra picked up her pace as her forces started charging behind her. Her shots weren't as accurate at a full run, but she still managed to take out a few troopers. A belated barrage of rockets came from the left flank, destroying the second walker. The camp was close now; the stormtroopers were finally forming battle lines and returning fire. Flicking her rifle into full-auto fire, Catra squeezed the trigger and swept the hail of bolts across the line. She slung the rifle across her back and grabbed her electrostaff as the soldier to her left threw a thermal detonator. The blast tore a hole in the troopers' formation just before the two sides clashed.

Catra's staff was a whirling blur of metal and crackling electricity as she launched herself at the Imperials. Stormtroopers dropped with loud *crack!* s. She targeted officers quickly, using her vibroknife to cut into their unarmored chests and throats. She lost count of how many Imperials she took down in the first five minutes; in the next five it was over. She stood in a mass of bodies, dead gang members slumped over white armor and grey officer's clothing. Her remaining troops milled about, some picking over the corpses for working blasters and valuables. A few grabbed Imperial E-11s to replace their guns.

Adora found her standing there, chest still heaving. Sweat plastered the blonde's hair to her forehead, grime covered her face, and her jumpsuit sported a new blaster burn on the left shoulder. "It's over," she said, stepping up next to Catra.

"Yeah. It's over," Catra repeated, her voice even more lifeless than normal through her helmet.

"What's wrong, Cat?"

"They didn't run."

Adora stared at her. Catra pulled her helmet off and met her gaze. Her eyes were haunted. "Every battle. They've run, dodged, tried to get some distance, *anything* . But they just… They threw themselves at me. They didn't even flinch when I tore out their Lieutenant's throat."

Adora knelt down and pulled off one of the trooper's helmets. Human, real flesh. She knew 501st training was strict, but Catra was describing almost robotic behavior.

"Adora…" Catra's voice was breathless. Adora looked up and saw what had taken her breath away. She had pulled off another one of the helmets, and the faces were *exactly* the same.

"They're clones," Adora whispered.

Shiver

Catra didn't sleep that night, or the next. She was haunted by images of blaster-burned stormtroopers charging at her with reckless abandon and their mangled bodies piled around her. The one time she slipped into a restless sleep she was jolted awake minutes later by nightmares of faceless men running at her, a red saberstaff swirling around her head as she cut them down, heads and arms and legs falling, separated from their owners.

The third night she couldn't do it alone. The desperate fear in her voice had convinced Adora to stay the night with her, so when she jolted awake screaming just after midnight it was in the arms of her girlfriend.

"Hey, hey, it's okay, Cat. I'm here. It's just a dream," she soothed quietly, gently stroking down Catra's arms, her back, her hair. "It's okay. I'm here. Relax for me, baby."

Catra didn't respond the first time. The second time was worse. Adora was tired, obviously having been woken up by her, and Catra was shivering and screaming still. She was feverish, her eyes glazed over. She lashed out when Adora tried to touch her, leaving scratches across her cheeks and forearms. It took over an hour for her to finally calm down enough to let Adora help her.

"Shh, baby. It's okay," Adora whispered, finally holding Catra's shivering body in her arms. Her skin was on fire, so hot from the fever that Adora could've sworn it was burning her. She held her there for what felt like a lifetime, cradling her beloved while she suffered. Not being able to help any more tore at Adora's heart.

Eventually, Catra spoke. "Water," she choked out through chattering teeth, her voice hoarse. Adora complied, bringing her a glass of water as quickly as she could. Catra sipped it slowly, relishing the cool water on her sore throat. Adora took the glass back and set it aside once she finished it.

"What's going on, Cat?" she prodded gently.

"I don't know," Catra whispered, still struggling to talk. "I keep having nightmares. Visions. Awful ones."

"About what, baby? Let me help you," Adora said, her voice still gentle.

"Clones. Fighting them, out there. The way they had no regard for their own survival. The way their armor and bones collapsed under my staff. The way they ignored pain just to try and kill me." The glazed, haunted look returned to Catra's eyes. "I keep having visions of being in a dark room, holding a red lightsaber while hordes of them rush at me. Faceless. Unarmed. Unarmored. Charging into my lightsaber as hundreds of dismembered, mangled bodies pile up around me. I can *feel them* , Adora. Fear and anger and *pain* . Assaulting my mind, digging into me as one by one they're silenced, only to be replaced by more. All *exactly the same* ."

"Catra, it's just a dream. Just a nightmare. That's all."

Catra's eyes snapped to her. "No. It's not, Adora. That's exactly how they felt *out there* . When was the last time you saw someone reduced to a shivering, broken mess over 'just a nightmare?'" She paused, looking out the window towards the dirty grey light of the early sunrise. "It haunts me. I've killed more people than I can count, but the one constant is that they had free will. They could run when they were scared. They could defend themselves when they were injured. It'd be one thing if it was droids, if they were programmed for this. But these are still *people* . They have feelings, fears, desires. I can feel them reach out for help, but all their bodies can do are try to kill me and die. The same voice, screaming 'Save me! Please!' thousands of times over before being cut off by *me* ." Finally, on the last word, Catra broke. She heaved out a dry sob before tears started streaming from her eyes. Adora put a hand on her shoulder, then pulled her close when she didn't object.

“Catra, I can’t fix it,” she whispered. “But I’m right here, okay? I’m right here. I’m not going anywhere. I promise.”

Her shoulder rocked as she sobbed into Adora’s chest. Adora’s arms tightened around her, one hand stroking through her hair and gently scratching behind her ears. Eventually, Catra slipped into sleep again. Cradled in Adora’s arms, it seemed more restful than before but Adora could still feel her tensing. The fever didn’t subside either.

They stayed together in Catra’s apartment for the next week. Each night, they repeated the same thing. Catra fell asleep, then bolted awake screaming less than two hours later. She was still sick. Sometimes it seemed like she was getting better, but most of the time she stayed the same or was on a slow decline.

The fifth night, Catra’s screaming woke Adora to a whirlwind of assorted items from their bedroom. Catra’s eyes were still squeezed shut as the wind picked up, flinging objects faster and faster.

Adora grabbed her by her shoulders and shook her. “Cat! Catra! Wake up! You have to wake up!” she screamed. She felt panic and terror setting in as Catra didn’t respond for a minute, but eventually she opened her eyes. Everything slammed down, various items and articles of clothing skittering across the floor with the last of their momentum.

Catra’s eyes had that same glazed over look, like she couldn’t see Adora. She stared through her, off into the distance. Adora kept shaking her, kept begging her to wake up, but she didn’t. After a half-hour, she fell back to the bed with her eyes closed. Adora couldn’t sleep for the rest of the night, anxiously pacing and watching Catra.

At dawn, Catra finally woke up. Adora bolted to her side, gently helping her out of bed.

"I'm fine, Adora. At least as fine as I can be right now. What's got you so freaked?" Catra grumbled, wiping at her eyes.

"Do you not remember anything from last night?" Adora asked, still not letting go of her.

"Remember *what* , Adora? The one night I didn't wake up?"

Adora paused. If this was being caused by Catra being scared and traumatized, telling her what had happened the night before might make it worse.

"You were just mumbling and thrashing in your sleep," Adora lied. "I thought maybe something different was going on."

Catra shook her head. "I had a more intense dream last night, but I stayed asleep this time. It's gotta be getting better." Adora just nodded, hoping Catra was right.

Nothing abnormal happened the next two nights. Late on the seventh morning, Catra's fever broke.

"I still feel like shit," Catra muttered, gratefully taking the glass of water Adora offered her.

"But you aren't about to melt my clothes off," Adora said, half-teasing.

Catra grinned up at her. "Shame I never did," she teased back. Adora's face went scarlet, prompting Catra to roll her eyes and laugh.

Adora stuttered for a moment, finally saying, "If you're feeling good enough to want my clothes off, you're good enough to get out of bed and come eat in the kitchen." She turned and walked out, leaving Catra staring affectionately after her.

She grabbed her comm before she got up and keyed in a call to Hope. They responded immediately.

"Master Catra! What is it you require?"

"Just checking on the ship, Hope," Catra said, grabbing a clean shirt to change into. "What have I missed?"

"Ah! The ship is in perfect condition. Myself and the Imperial Guards have ensured it operates at peak performance at all times."

"Good. Anything important to tell me?"

"One of the Emperor's messengers contacted us four days ago, Master Catra." She froze. "He requested your presence, but I informed him that you were too sick to appear before him and I would notify you as soon as you were well."

Fuck. "I'm fine now. Schedule it and let me know when I'm expected."

"As you wish, Master Catra. Is there anything else?"

"That's all, Hope. Thanks." She closed the channel.

With a new change of clothes, Catra left the room and met Adora at the table. "How do you feel?" her girlfriend asked, sliding her a plate of eggs and sausage.

"Fine," Catra murmured, eating the food slowly. Adora didn't press her, but she could feel the blonde's eyes burning into her. "The Emperor wants to meet again."

Adora nodded in understanding. "Maybe he just has a mission for us," she offered, setting her fork down.

"Yeah, maybe," Catra replied unconvincingly. They finished breakfast in silence.

After eating, Catra grabbed her staff and took Adora to the room she had cleaned out for training.

"Everything's over there," she said, gesturing to a wall with a variety of weapons hanging from it. Including, Adora noticed, the sword Catra had let her use on the way to Coruscant. Catra saw the way her eyes lingered on it. "It's yours if you want it, Adora."

She gingerly picked it up. "You mean?..."

Catra nodded. "You can keep it. It's just been sitting around for years. I want you to have it."

Adora hefted it, feeling the way it settled perfectly into her hands. There was a weird sense of familiarity with this sword.

While Adora was mesmerized with the sword, Catra watched her. This time she was *sure* she wasn't imagining the glow around Adora. She didn't look taller this time, though. Catra twirled her staff once, drawing Adora's attention.

"We gonna do this?" she asked.

"You sure you're up to it?"

Catra shrugged. "Won't know if I don't try. Now come on."

Adora nodded, then lunged at her.

An hour passed. Catra was breathing heavily, but Adora again didn't even look winded. Her saving grace was her comm activating, giving her an excuse to stop Adora.

"Go ahead," she said, accepting the call.

"Master Catra, the Emperor wishes to meet with you today," Hope said.

"When?"

"In three hours. You may want to begin preparing."

"Got it. Thanks, Hope."

The channel closed and Catra looked up at Adora. "We should shower," Adora said.

" *I* should shower. You look like you've been sitting there doing nothing for the past hour," Catra retorted.

Adora looked down at herself and a flicker of surprise jumped over her face. "Wow, uh, I really do, huh?"

"Stop fucking bragging," Catra grumbled.

"I'm not!" Adora defended.

Catra just rolled her eyes and left, dropping her staff against the doorframe. Adora didn't follow. She stripped quickly and showered, spending some extra time to soothe her aching arms and shoulders.

When she got out, she put on the most presentable outfit she could; a black undershirt and form-fitting pants, her Mandalorian armor minus the helmet, and one of her various black cloaks and capes, a knee length one with no hood this time. She made an imposing figure, all-black from head to toe, only broken up by the occasional silver accents in her armor and her bright eyes. She clipped her lightsaber to her belt for the first time in weeks and slid a blaster into the holster on her thigh.

She grabbed her helmet, spending a moment to look at it. It's traditional T-visor was slanted, making more of a Y. It was much lighter than most and designed to more closely fit her face than the typical cylindrical Mandalorian helmets. Though she enjoyed most of her time with the Mandalorians, she had always been averse to their traditions, so nobody was surprised when she requested armor of a different design than theirs.

She pulled the helmet on and the white HUD lit up, giving her a readout on her armor's systems and her own vitals. Light's voice filled her ears.

“Hello, Lady Catra. All systems are in peak condition. Awaiting your command.”

Catra gave the readouts a once-over, wanting to confirm Light’s report herself. Once she was satisfied, she took it off and cradled it under her arm. She wasn’t due to the Emperor’s palace for another two hours, but there was nothing wrong with being early, right?

“Hey, Adora!” she called as she left her room. “I’m leaving!”

Adora came out of the kitchen carrying a half-eaten sandwich. “Oh! Already?”

“Yeah. I’m sick of being cooped up in here, at least waiting in the palace will be a change of scenery,” Catra answered. “Should I expect you here when I get back?”

Adora hesitated. “Do you want me here when you get back?” she asked quietly.

“Adora, if I wasn’t almost-dying this week would’ve been the happiest I’ve ever been,” Catra said. Deciding to take a chance, she continued. “I want you here always, every day and night.”

“You know I can’t, Cat.”

“Just... Think about it, okay?” she said. Adora nodded. “See you later?”

“Yeah. Be careful.” Adora stepped forward and hugged her.

“I always am, princess,” Catra whispered into her ear. She pulled away and walked out the door, giving the blonde a cocky grin.

She put the helmet back on in the turbolift. Mandalorians got odd looks wherever they went, but a Mandalorian without her helmet on would get even more. The HUD lit up and Light spoke again.

"Light, lower the sensitivity on external mics. I don't wanna be deafened once I'm out there."

"Understood, Lady Catra." The *whoosh* of the turbolift dropped in volume immediately.

"Thanks. Notify the Imperial Palace I'll be there early and hail a cab for me, too."

"Immediately, Lady Catra."

The doors slid open to a busy lobby. Deliveries, residents and visitors coming and going, and the occasional Coruscant officer on patrol. She cut through the crowd with ease. Those who weren't smart enough to make a path for her were easy enough to slip by. A cab was waiting for her outside.

"Where to?" the driver asked impatiently.

"Imperial Palace."

The speeder cab took off. Catra looked out the window. Coruscant was her home planet, but the upper levels were still mostly unfamiliar to her.

She didn't pay attention to how long the ride took. Coruscant's cabs were fast, but they were pretty far from the palace. The palace itself was massive. She had been born before the Republic fell, but she wasn't old enough to remember when the Imperial Palace was the Jedi Temple. Dee had told her stories about it. They described the Jedi as "self-righteous bastards with no sense of style, but better than the Empire."

Modified TIE Interceptors, painted the bloody crimson of the Imperial Guard, circled the palace. A TIE model Catra couldn't place sat on one of the landing platforms.

"Light, can you identify that fighter?"

"One moment, Lady Catra." A pause. "Reports indicate it is a Sienar TIE Advanced starfighter. It's owner can be identified as Darth Vader with 93% certainty."

"Thanks, Light. Any word on our meeting?"

"The Imperial Palace has communicated that the Emperor is ready for your arrival."

"Good."

Catra walked through the palace's main doors and towards the Emperor's throne room. She was stopped just outside by the Imperial Guard; after identifying herself, she was allowed in.

The Emperor sat on his throne, facing her. As she expected, Vader was with him. She could hear his labored, mechanical breathing from where she stood. His lightsaber hung at his hip, his arms crossed over his chest.

"You wanted to see me?" she asked, ignoring Vader for the moment.

"Yes. The Empire is aware of your… *interference* , hunter," the Emperor said. Despite the implied threat in his words, his tone was light. As light as it could get, anyways.

"I don't know what you're talking about," Catra said flatly, crossing her arms.

"Do not think you can feign innocence," Vader said. "Your attack on the 501st legion did not go unnoticed."

She could tell lying wouldn't help her. "What's wrong, Vader? Sad that we fucked up your precious stormtroopers?" The rage pouring off of the Dark Lord was palpable.

"Please," interrupted the Emperor, "let us handle this with civility. Hunter, I haven't called you here for a punishment or

lecture. I simply request that you cease your involvement in Coruscant's gang wars."

"Not happening."

The Emperor sighed. "I'm sure you're aware that Coruscant's underworld is in a delicate balance. The Empire tolerates the gangs so long as they don't get in our way. Your allies have seen fit to do exactly that."

"Not my problem."

"You have seen fit to make it your problem, hunter. I am simply asking you to ignore it."

"Then leave them alone." Catra was a little angry now. She was a retainer, not a servant. The Empire wasn't her master.

"We have already attempted to resolve the matter peacefully. They had no interest in doing so." The Emperor was still calm. Diplomacy was his natural medium; he fully expected her to give in.

"The fastest way to resolve the situation is to withdraw your support and leave the Krayts alone," Catra retorted.

"I am giving you one final chance. Abandon the war. I will continue providing you with targets and credits."

"Not a chance. You don't control me." Catra had a feeling it was a mistake, but abandoning Dee would be a bigger one.

"As you wish, hunter. Lord Vader?"

The hulking cyborg stepped forward. "Yes, master?"

"Destroy her."

Before the words could leave his mouth, Catra drew her blaster and lightsaber in one smooth motion, firing a barrage of shots at

Vader. With a wave of his hand, they were cast aside. His scarlet lightsaber sprang to life as he floated down the steps.

"You are nothing, bounty hunter. And you will die as nothing," he growled. Holstering her blaster, Catra leapt forward.

"Light, prep all auxiliary weapons for combat!" she snapped, meeting Vader's crushing blow with her own lightsaber.

"Yes, Lady Catra. All weapons ready and at your disposal."

Their blades were locked together. Vader was far stronger than her and his added height gave him leverage. Catra slid his blade to the side and dodged away. The momentary lull let her feel the Emperor's glee as he watched them. Why he was so happy she had no idea. Sadism, probably.

Vader didn't give her much longer, though. He stepped forward and struck again, which she deftly parried and twirled away from. He was strong, yes, but slow. His strikes were wide and somewhat sloppy. Trying to block them head-on was suicide, but she could outpace him.

So she did. She dodged most attacks, deflecting the ones she couldn't avoid entirely. She was still on her back foot, but the longer Vader pressed his offensive the faster he would grow tired. Despite rumors of him being a droid, she could feel that he was a real person; besides, droids couldn't use the force.

Eventually, he caught her against a wall and landed a blow. His blade struck her shoulder and dragged across her chest, leaving a burning line in her armor. Internally, she thanked her Mandalorian forgemaster for not skimping on her armor's beskar. Still, the strike had damaged it and temporarily immobilized her.

Vader lifted his saber, ready for the killing blow, and that's where she got her chance. She swept her blade up, scoring his chest armor and searing off part of his helmet. He stumbled back, reaching up to touch the exposed part of his face.

"This armor's expensive, *asshole* ," Catra snarled, lunging at him again. Though slightly off-balance still, he blocked her strike and tossed her aside with the force. She rolled across the floor before skidding to a stop, shaking herself off as she stood.

"Perhaps I underestimated you," Vader said. His helmet's speakers were far louder than his voice, but Catra's sensitive, force-enhanced hearing could pick up hints of it. "But you will die all the same."

"Try me," Catra responded, lifting her lightsaber into a far more aggressive stance. Vader marched towards her, his single exposed eye full of anger. Catra felt her own anger surge through her as they met.

Suddenly she was a kid again. Eleven years old, going through the Mandalorians' relentless training. Again and again she failed, earning hard strikes from her teacher's training blade.

"Can't you go any easier on me?" she asked, panting.

"No, little cat. You have to be ready. That means you need to be strong and fast. Now, again. You can rest after this."

Catra nodded, lifting her sword.

Blow after blow met between them, each knocked aside with the same force it was delivered. But slowly, Vader was being beaten back. Catra wasn't thinking anymore. Every strike was years of pain and anger; anger for being abandoned as a child, anger for the Mandalorians making her one of them, anger for being forced to leave Adora, anger for never being able to be happy. And with each of them, Vader fell back farther. With each of them, his block grew weaker. His own strikes were slower, sloppier, easier to swat away. And finally, eventually, he made a fatal mistake.

Vader lifted his arms, looking to deliver a single, deadly blow from above, and Catra's saber caught him. It cut through his wrists, severing his hands as sparks flew from the cut wires. His lightsaber clattered to the ground and Catra threw him backwards with one powerful force push. As he stumbled to his knees, she put her blade at his throat.

"If you want your *lapdog* alive, you're going to withdraw support from the Canyon Devils and leave the Krayts alone. You and your Empire won't interfere with them again," she said, directing her anger towards the Emperor.

Instead of any reasonable emotion, the air was *thick* with excitement. "What makes you think I want him alive, hunter?" Her and Vader's eyes both snapped to the Emperor, shock in both. "He has failed me time and again. You, however, are yet to do so." He stood, making his way down to stand next to them. "Kill him, hunter. Take your place as my apprentice."

Catra's grip tightened on her lightsaber. "Why the *hell* would I do that?"

"Your beloved Adora." Catra gasped. "She is not in danger. But I know of your relationship. Her superiors would not tolerate such a breach of conduct; but if you were to take Lord Vader's place, they would have no choice but to allow it. After all, who would dare cross a Dark Lady of the Sith?"

Catra's mind was racing. If the Emperor knew about her and Adora, it was only a matter of time before he used it against her. She could kill him in a fight, sure. He was strong, but strength didn't matter if she got just one chance to cut him off from the force. But she couldn't risk losing Adora again. She looked down at Vader, at the single, exposed, yellow eye. It was wide. Fear and panic were clear there.

"All you have to do is give in. Your anger is strong, hunter. Let it guide you. Strike him down and stand by my side. You will rule the galaxy as my right hand, you and your beloved," the

Emperor's voice was persuasive. "One strike, and you will have all the power you could ever imagine."

Catra was trapped. The Emperor had the power here. If she walked away, she would lose Adora. But she didn't want to be a Sith. Did she?...

Sense darkness from you, I do not. The voice of the strange creature on Dagobah echoed through her head. It had said there wasn't darkness in her, but she could feel it. She was brimming with it, ready to boil over. The visions of the red saberstaff played out in front of her. She had never cared for the force's guidance and it never seemed to seek her out. But was this it? Was this her destiny?

She saw Adora. Saw her laughing, smiling, hugging her. Saw her in custom red armor, seated together in matching thrones. Her blonde hair was down, flowing over her shoulders in golden waves. Their hands were interlocked as they looked out over their Empire. They shared a kiss, reveling in each other's presence, in their combined power.

Catra gave in.

The Lady Horde

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Vader's decapitated body slumped to the ground, his head landing with a heavy *thunk* . The Emperor stared at the body for a moment before turning to Catra.

"He was *weak* . You are not. Now, Catra. Kneel, and be anointed as my apprentice," he said, taking a single step back.

Catra knelt, bowing her head to her new master. She still held her lightsaber, though she had deactivated it. "Yes, my lord," she said quietly.

"Good. I name you Darth Horde, Dark Lady of the Sith. Rise, my apprentice."

Horde rose, meeting the Sith Lord's gaze with her own. "What would you command of me, master?"

"First, the gang wars of Coruscant must be resolved. You have a choice before you." Horde waited patiently for the Emperor to continue. "You may take a legion of stormtroopers with you to the underbelly of Coruscant and exterminate the Golden Krayts, ending their meddling. Or, you may contact them and use your position as my right hand to bring them into the Empire."

"I will see if I can change their minds first, master," Horde said, clipping her lightsaber to her belt. "They may be useful to us."

"Hmm. And you still harbor some affection for them, apprentice. Do not seek to cloud your motives; they are of no importance to me. Simply do as instructed."

"Yes, master." She bowed her head again. "May I contact them here?"

"As you wish," the Emperor answered.

Dee took a moment to answer, but they did. "Catra! It's good to hear from you! How do you- Why is the Emperor here?" they said, immediately on guard.

"Dee," Horde said, stepping forward to assert her presence, "on behalf of the Emperor and Galactic Empire, I would extend to you an offer of peace and allyship."

"On behalf of the- Cat, what the hell is going on?" they exclaimed.

"Present circumstances are unimportant," the Sith responded. "You and your gang are being offered a position of protection within the Empire. All that would be expected is your support in return. You would be wise to accept."

"'Our support?' Catra, what are you talking about? What 'support?' And why are you talking like that?"

"Dee, I cannot offer you any more leniency. Do you accept this offer?"

"Okay, you know what? I'm gonna bring a diplomatic entourage up there and we can talk. Sound good?" they said.

Horde looked to her master, who nodded. "We will be waiting." Dee closed the channel.

"Do you think they will surrender to us?" the Emperor asked.

"They don't have a choice, master. They were only winning this war because of my involvement; without it, they will be crushed if they don't give in."

He nodded. "Very good. Once this has been dealt with, you will be free to deal with more important tasks."

"What tasks, master?" Horde asked.

“A rebellion has been brewing; now, it has boiled over. You will be sent to squash it before it spreads.”

“With glee, my lord.”

The Emperor smiled beneath his hood.

While Dee made their way to the Imperial Palace, Darth Horde was outfitted with equipment more befitting a Dark Lady of the Sith. Her armor was left untouched for the moment, though the Emperor promised it would be modified in the future, but she was given a new weapon and her torn cape was replaced.

“I know that you are fond of your electrostaff, my apprentice. Such a lowly weapon cannot be wielded by a Sith Lord, so I have seen fit to provide you with a lightsaber to replace it,” he said, handing her a saberstaff. It was just short enough to be wielded one-handed, with only one blade, while still being an effective staff.

“With respect, my lord, my lightsaber is special. It is the only one I have ever found capable of functioning when I apply my abilities, so I will need to continue carrying it,” she said, analyzing the new saber. It was a simple black hilt, sturdy with just enough weight to feel like a weapon.

“Of course, apprentice. I believe we can forego the trial of building a lightsaber and bleeding a crystal; yours has a very special connection to you. I only wish to provide you with the appropriate tools to be my instrument of fear and destruction.”

“Yes, my lord,” Horde responded, finally igniting the saber. Two crimson blades burst from the ends. She held it there for a moment, feeling its balance, before deactivating it and clipping it just behind her saber. Her dueling saber, now. She had a feeling this saberstaff would be a far better weapon for her in all other situations. “Thank you.” She bowed slightly.

When they returned to the throne room, they were informed that Dee and their group of advisors had arrived. The Emperor instructed them to be let in and settled into his throne.

Vader's body still rested at the bottom of the stairs and it was the second thing Dee noticed, the first being Horde's position at the Emperor's right hand. Their advisors whispered among themselves and pointed at Vader's body.

Horde walked down the stairs and gracefully moved to welcome Dee, removing her helmet as she did so. "Thank you for coming. I promise, our terms will be beneficial to us both."

"Before we talk business you're going to tell me what's going on, kitten," Dee demanded, trying and failing to soften the edge in their voice with the pet name.

"There will be time for explanations later. This is time-sensitive."

Dee scowled but acquiesced, following Horde to stand before the Emperor. She resumed her place to his right, waiting for him to speak.

"Welcome to the Imperial Palace, Double Trouble," he said. "I trust my guards did not keep you waiting long?"

"No, your Imperial Majesty," they answered. "I mean no offence, my lord, but I desire these talks to be over as quickly as possible. Though not as grand or important as yours, I have my own small empire to run."

"Of course," he said. "I, too, wish for these talks to go quickly and smoothly. As my loyal agent here has no doubt already told you, your cooperation will benefit your empire as well as mine."

"That remains to be seen, my lord. My business is very lucrative; being associated with the ruling authority could very well harm that business," Dee said diplomatically.

"Yes, I understand that well. I am not asking you to openly align with us, nor to share details of your dealings. I simply request that your dealings with the newly-founded rebellion cease and for you to function as a middleman for the Empire and the underworld."

"And in return?" Dee was interested, though at the moment it seemed more like curiosity than consideration.

"You shall have Imperial support if you ever have need of it. Your claim to the Coruscant underworld will not be disputed by any Imperial-backed group, nor will the Empire treat you as a high-threat organization. If it becomes necessary, the Lady Horde," he gestured at Horde, causing Dee to straighten in surprise, "will intervene on your behalf. I will also instruct Coruscant customs officers to turn a blind eye to any… less-than-legal shipments you import or export."

Horde knew that offer was too good to pass up. Buying customs officers was expensive and sneaking illegal items past them was practically impossible. Having them in the Krayts' pockets for free would open up resources Dee typically considered unusable and allow them to increase the gang's income drastically.

"The Empire would make no move to publicly support the Golden Krayts, correct?" they asked after a pause. The Emperor nodded. Dee took a deep breath. "Then I accept your terms. The Krayts will cease trade with known and suspected rebels."

"Good. This has been very productive," the Emperor said. "Now, Lady Horde, I believe your friend wanted a word with you?"

Horde nodded and followed Dee out of the throne room. As soon as they were out of earshot of the guards, Dee spun towards her.

"What is *happening* , Catra? What did he call you? 'Horde?' His 'loyal agent?'"

"Chill, Dee," Catra said, putting a hand on their shoulder. "Sit down, okay? I'll start from the beginning."

She recounted the day's events from when she arrived at the palace, detailing her duel with Vader, killing him, and becoming the Emperor's apprentice.

"Okay, so, I was like 90% sure he was a Sith *anyways* , but you're telling me you're his *apprentice* now?" Dee hissed.

"Yeah, I guess," Catra said, shrugging.

"Do you understand what the Sith are, Cat? They're *evil* . They almost destroyed the Republic thousands of years ago and apparently this one succeeded. You can't be serious about this!"

"Dee, I can't risk me and Adora being found out and losing her again. Nobody would challenge our relationship while I'm the Emperor's right hand."

"What, you think she's just gonna be okay with her girlfriend being a fucking *Sith Lord?* " Dee stared at her incredulously.

"She works for them. What, you think the Imperial Guard doesn't know?"

"Working for them and dating one of them are *so* different, Cat," Dee said.

Catra just shrugged again. "Why? Dee, I hunt Jedi for a living anyways. This is the same thing with a cushier position and more power."

"Whatever. I won't sit here and fight you on choices you can't take back, just be careful, okay?" Their eyes softened. "I don't want to lose you. You've always been like a daughter to me, kitten. I'll be here if you need anything."

Catra nodded, smiling gently at them. "I'm always careful, Dee," she said, standing up to hug them. "Stay safe. And tell me if

you need me too, okay? Whether you need your friend Catra, or a Sith Lord."

Dee smiled a little. "I will." With that, they left. Catra watched them go, satisfied she had put their fears to rest. She walked back into the throne room, the guards parting for her immediately.

"My lord, I request your leave to return home and see Adora," she said, kneeling before the Emperor.

"Request granted, apprentice. Rest well tonight. Tomorrow, your trials and training will begin."

"Yes, my lord." Catra left, slightly uneasy about what was in store for her the following day.

It was late when she got home, but Adora was there like she promised. The blonde met her girlfriend with a hug as soon as she walked in. She buried her face in her neck before pulling back and wrinkling her nose.

"You need a shower, Cat."

"I'm not surprised. Let me clean off, then we need to talk." Adora nodded, worry flitting across her face for a moment.

Catra showered, trying to be as quick as possible. Between her statement before going to clean herself and it going on the eighth night of Adora staying over, she knew her girlfriend would be anxious. She changed into nightclothes and went out to see Adora fidgeting on the couch.

"What's up?" Adora asked, trying to be nonchalant.

"First of all, it's nothing bad so you can calm down," Catra said, taking her hands in her own. Adora visibly relaxed, but wasn't completely soothed. "Let's start with the good news and then work towards the weird news, okay?" Adora nodded. "Okay, best

news: the gang war is over for good and the Krayts won." Adora's eyes widened, but Catra cut off her questions before she could ask. "Next, you don't have to worry about staying with me anymore. You won't get in trouble and I can guarantee that. No questions, we're getting there. Third, Darth Vader is dead."

Adora let out an audible gasp at that one and couldn't hold back her questions anymore. "How is that good news, Cat? I know you're not an Empire fan, but we do *work* for him!"

"If you would wait, I could tell you that it's good news because… I took his place." Adora froze. "I know that you know about the Emperor, Adora," Catra whispered, meeting her gaze softly. "He had Vader attack me, and when I won he told me to kill him and made me his apprentice."

Adora leaned back, processing the news. "So you're… a Sith now?" she asked. Catra nodded. "I just… Wow. That's a lot. Should I be like, kneeling?"

Catra started to smile, then realized Adora was totally serious. "Adora, this doesn't change us. It just means we can be openly together and that everything we need will be provided by the Empire, even luxury shit."

"Cat, you're a Sith Lord. You're like, only second to the Emperor himself. You're the most powerful woman in the galaxy now. Am I even *allowed* to call you Cat now? I should be calling you, what, Lord? Lady?"

Catra cut off her rambling. "Adora, I know this is a lot and really sudden but we aren't changing. Not if you still want me," she added, her voice quieting. That kicked Adora's brain into gear.

"Of course I want you, Cat. You're right, it's just a lot. I need to process, but I want to be with you. I want to be with you regardless of where we are. I mean, what does being the Emperor's apprentice even entail?"

Catra shrugged. “He didn’t really specify. Mostly killing people though, probably. He said there was a rebellion trying to take root that he needed me to put down, and that tomorrow we’d begin my ‘trials,’ whatever that means.”

“Okay, well… You said we finally get to be open?” Catra nodded. “Good. I’m sick of hiding us.” Adora smiled softly and cupped one of Catra’s cheeks in her hand. “Since you’ve already invited me, can I live here? With you?”

“Of course, Adora. I want that more than anything,” Catra said.

“I love you, Cat.”

“I love you too.” They stared at each other for a moment. “Kiss me, dummy,” Catra said, giggling a little. Adora laughed and leaned forward, pressing their lips together.

Chapter End Notes

This is the end of the fic, but not the end of the story. Part 2 will resume a year down the road, at the beginning of A New Hope, and will focus much more heavily on how Catra’s involvement affects the Galactic Civil War and story of the original trilogy.

End Notes

This definitely started as an OC in place of Catra, but my mind started making a story too perfect for anything but catradora so enjoy. Idk how long it'll be yet so stay tuned. Also, she/they Catra is a thing here but they is used sparingly.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!